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THE RISING NEPAL

ALL BE HAPPY, ALL BE WELL



PHOTO: KABIN ADHIKARI/TRN

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda', Nepali Congress President Sher Bahadur Deuba and senior leaders of different political parties attending a symposium to mark National Unity and Reconciliation Day in the capital on Monday.

National Reconciliation Day observed

Nepali leaders are inspired by BP: PM

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 1

Nepali Congress marked the 48th National Reconciliation Day by holding various programmes across the country on Monday.

Nepali Congress has been celebrating the National Reconciliation Day every year on January 16 to commemorate the day when the party's founding leader Bishweshwar Prasad Koirala and other leaders returned home from India by embracing the principle of national unity and reconciliation in 1977.

In Kathmandu, the NC marked the day by organising a special programme at the Nepal Academy, Kamaladi.

Interestingly, the event was attended by the top leaders of the three political parties including Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda'.

Addressing the event, Prime Minister and Chairman of the Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Maoist) Prachanda said that all the parties and leaders of Nepal are inspired by the late BP Koirala's ideals in one way or another.

PM Prachanda mentioned that there was no doubt that Koirala, the founder of the Nepali Congress, was the patriarch and popular leader of Nepal's democratic movement.

"The current ruling coalition will last for the entire term and this will bring prosperity to the people. The NC should be able to confidently own the good works done by the present government," said PM Prachanda.

He informed that the present government has done good work in social justice, giving justice to the victims of loan sharks and solving the citizenship problem, and labour issues. "Furthermore, the government has done its best to provide immediate assistance to the people whenever and wherever they are suffering," added the PM.

He expressed grief over the incident that claimed the lives of two youths in Lalitpur's Balkumari on Friday and informed that a committee was formed to investigate the incident and that the work of providing relief to the victim's family had moved ahead.

President of Nepali Congress and former Prime Minister Sher Bahadur Deuba said that democracy is the key to progress and urged one and all not to think about alternatives. "The necessity and justification of reconciliation in Nepal is increasing, so everyone should move ahead together," he said.

Deuba said, "The policy propounded by BP Koirala helps promote harmony and unity. Now the need for it in our country has increased even more. People who are looking for various excuses are trying to create an environment against democracy and republic. The alternative to democracy is a better democracy and there is no alternative to it," added Deuba.

Deuba said that harmony and unity among the political parties in Nepal is a good thing amid fierce competition against each other. Similarly, the Chairman of the main opposition party CPN (UML) and former Prime Minister KP Sharma Oli said that he had no desire to play within Nepali Congress.

» SEE PAGE 6

High level panel formed to probe Balkumari incident

BY PURUSHOTTAM P. KHATRI
Kathmandu, Jan. 1

» CABINET DECISIONS

The government has formed a High-level Probe Commission headed by former judge Shekhar Paudel to investigate into the Balkumari incident that occurred last Friday.

The Commission was formed by a Cabinet meeting held at the Office of Prime Minister and Council of Ministers in Singha Durbar on Monday morning.

The meeting designated former AIG of Nepal Police Arun B.C. as member and Joint Secretary of the Ministry of Home Affairs and Spokesperson of the Ministry Narayan Prasad Bhattarai as member-secretary of the commission.

The commission has been given one month's time to submit the report. The commission will start working from Monday, said Minister for Communication and Information Technology Rekha Sharma after the Cabinet meeting.

Minister Sharma, who is also the Spokesperson of the Ministry, said the Commission would study and analyse the details of the human, physical and other damages caused in the incident, study the cause of the incident and the security plan made at the location and identify the deficiencies in it.

Similarly, the Commission is given authority to investigate the role of the persons, officials and agencies related to the Balkumari incident and recommend action for their mistakes.

Minister Sharma said that the Commission would carry out the study of the incident and recommend action to anyone found guilty.

The Ministry of Home Affairs had previously constituted a 3-member investigation committee under the leadership of Deputy Inspector General of Police Lalmani Acharya on December 29 to investigate the incident.

In the Balkumari incident, Birendra Shah of Achham and Sujan Rawat of Dailekh were killed and the vehicle of Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport Prakash Jwala was set on fire.

PM Prachanda implements austerity measures

Meanwhile, the government, which has announced reforms in the entire structure of the state, has begun the process by deciding to scrap lunch expenses of the Cabinet meeting to be provided to all the ministers to come into effect from Monday onwards.

Prime Minister Pushpa Kamal Dahal 'Prachanda' briefed about the decision that the lunch expenses of the meeting have been cut from today, saying that reforms should be started from small things in the Cabinet meeting held at Singha Durbar on Monday morning.

According to the Prime Minister's Office, about Rs. 60,000 is spent on lunch for each Cabinet meeting. There are more than 100 Cabinet meetings in a year. Prime Minister Dahal's press advisor Govinda Acharya said that with the scrapping of lunch in the Cabinet, about Rs. 6 million will be saved annually.

Acharya said that Prime Minister Prachanda initiated reforms from his own office because even small things are considered important in good governance and reforms.

He said Prime Minister Prachanda, who has announced to change the working style of the government, reaches the Prime Minister's Office at Singh Durbar daily at 10 a.m. except on public holidays.

The Prime Minister has been taking daily 'briefings' of various ministries from Singha Durbar and taking initiatives to solve the problems encountered in projects such as of national pride.

7.6 MAGNITUDE QUAKE JOLTS JAPAN

AFP
Japan, Jan. 1

A succession of 21 earthquakes registering 4.0 magnitude or stronger struck central Japan in just over 90 minutes on Monday, the Japan Meteorological Agency said.

The strongest jolt measured 7.6, it said. The quakes prompted tsunami warnings and authorities urged people in the area to move to higher ground.

(See details on page 5)

BALKUMARI INCIDENT VICTIMS, GOVT REACH AGREEMENT

RSS
Kathmandu, Jan. 1

A four-point agreement has been reached between the government and the families of the person who were killed during the demonstration that took place at Balkumari in Lalitpur last Friday.

The discussion held between the two sides at the Ministry of Home Affairs led to an agreement whereby one member each of the family of the deceased will be provided suitable employment as soon as possible.

It has also been agreed between the two parties that in addition to the relief provided by the government, initiatives will be taken to declare the deceased as martyrs, the families of the deceased will receive the mortal remains today while the Ministry will help deliver the mortal remains to the respective home town.

Under Secretary at the Ministry of Home Affairs, Umakant Adhikari, on behalf of the government, and Tek Bahadur Shah and Tek Bahadur Katuwal, on behalf of the deceased's family, signed the agreement.

It may be noted that Birendra Shah of Chowrapati Rural Municipality-1 in Achham and Sujan Raut of Mahabu Rural Municipality-6 in Dailekh were killed after police fired at protestors during the demonstration that took place on Friday in front of Employment Permit System (EPS) Korea branch office at Balkumari.

Earlier today, the government formed a commission of inquiry led by former High Court judge Shekhar Paudel to carry out a fair and objective investigation of the incident.

Keeping life afloat rowing bamboos down Saptakoshi River



BY BABURAM KARKI
Barahakshetra, Jan. 1

Saptakoshi River causes great havoc during the monsoon. It is, however, a source of income for many during the winter.

Every year from October, people in Bhojpur, Dhankuta, Udayapur, Khotang and other hilly districts along the river begin collecting bamboo, tying them into makeshift rafts and rowing them to Sunsari. The bamboo is then sold in the Tarai.

Adip Rai, 32, of Belaka Municipality-6, Udayapur, said that he had been riding such bamboo skiffs for the past 17 years.

Similarly, Japan Rai, of the same ward, said he has been doing this for 16 years. "It is risky," he said. "We have to stay alert all the time. We may lose our lives but this is the only way to earn a living."

'Bamboo business' has generated employment directly and indirectly to dozens – from individuals chopping the bamboo to rowers making the rafts and taking them down the river, rowers pulling the tied bamboo out of the water, and porters loading them onto trucks. However, those involved in this business can work only for eight months a year when the Saptakoshi is not flooding.

Several persons The Rising Nepal talked to informed that they earned between Rs. 3,000 to 3,500 for every bundle of bamboo they brought to Sunsari. Each bundle contains about 150 culms of bamboo.

Raj Karki of Chatara, Sunsari, who has been dealing in bamboo for the past eight years, informed that they could make an annual profit of up to Rs. 500,000. "That's why we are willing to put our life at risk." He explained that bamboo worth Rs. 5 million was sold at Chatara alone every month.

Karki further shared that people earn Rs. 5 for every culm they pulled out of the water and porters get Rs. 3,500 for every truck they filled with bamboo. Each truck can transport 850 bamboo culms.

The bamboo thus brought is sold to contractors who, in turn, transport them to markets in Dharan, Biratnagar, Itahari, Palung, Kathamandu, Pokhara and as far as Dadeldhura.



Let's Create Employment: Dr. Mahat

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 1

Amidst the growing discontent in the private sector due to the recent row over the dedicated trunk line electricity supply and poor demand in the market, Finance Minister Dr. Prakash Sharan Mahat has said that the door of the Ministry of Finance is always open to solve the problems of the industrialists and address the challenges.

Speaking at the closing programme of Morang Merchants Association Expo in Biratnagar on Monday, FM Dr. Mahat said, "Send the problems of industrialists and businessmen in writing or meet directly and get the problem addressed through discussion."

He also urged the private sector to join hands with the government in creating employment, according to FM Dr. Mahat's secretariat. According to the Minister, Nepali economy was in trouble and there are still some problems, however, positive signs will be seen in the coming days and the country would be on the path of growth. He said, "Currently available data confirm what I said now. We had announced through the budget that the economic growth rate would be 6.5 per cent, now the inflation rate has dropped to 5.38 per cent. Since the price increase in the neighboring countries has been moderated, it has also helped us."



FILE PHOTO: TRN

Finance Minister Dr.Prakeshsaran Mahat.

Dr. Mahat also cited the upward trend in the stock market which has inched up from earlier 1800 and increased transactions in real estate to maintain that the economy is improving.

"Banks are reducing interest rates, which has led to an increase in credit flows, which may increase further in the coming days. The arrival of tourists is the highest ever," he said.

According to FM Dr. Mahat, poor infrastructure is the biggest challenge and due to poor infrastructure, potentials in tourism sector development have also been limited.

He said that in the coming days, the projects that will push the growth up would be prioritised and the budget will be allocated to the game changer projects. Minister Dr. Mahat said, "What is needed now is confidence, the negative propaganda that there is no future in this country has reduced confidence. When all the indicators of the economy are positive, I request the industrialists, civil society and the media to start a positive debate."

Dr. Mahat also assured the business community that the government would announce further measures to protect Nepali industry and businesses.

Expenditure on petroleum fuel drops by 5% in five months

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 1

Expenditure for the import of petroleum products has decreased during the first five months of the current fiscal year 2023/24. According to trade statistics of the Department of Customs, the country imported petroleum products worth Rs. 112.21 billion in first five months of the current fiscal year.

The expenditure for the import of petroleum products is almost 5 per cent lower during the review period of the current fiscal year as compared to the same period last year 2022/23. Petroleum products worth Rs. 117.60 billion had been imported in the first five months of the last fiscal year.

The fall in the price of petroleum products in the international market and its consumption have contributed to the decline in the expense of fuel import during the review period. The consumption of petroleum products, especially diesel, has decreased significantly in the country during the review period due to significant price hikes of petroleum products, slow pace of development works and improvement in the electricity supply in the country.

According to the statistics, about 489,936 kilolitres of diesel worth Rs. 53.90 billion and 281,970 kilolitres of petrol worth Rs. 28.55 billion have been imported during the first five months of the current fiscal year. Similarly, the country imported 78,112 kilolitres of aviation fuel worth Rs. 8.66 billion and 4,132 kilolitres of kerosene worth Rs. 452 million were imported during the review period.

The country had imported 424,510 kilolitres of diesel worth Rs. 55.48 billion and 279,459 kilolitres of petrol worth Rs. 28.59 billion during the first five months of the last fiscal year. Similarly, 74721 kilolitres of aviation fuel worth Rs. 9.20 billion and 4,344 kilolitres of kerosene worth Rs. 582 million were imported during the first five months of the last fiscal year.

In the meantime, the import of liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) has decreased in the first five months of the current fiscal year as compared to the same period last fiscal year. The statistics showed that the import of LPG in terms of money has been reduced by 13 per cent in the first five months of the current fiscal year as compared to the corresponding period last year.

Around 214,291 tonnes of LPG worth Rs. 20.65 billion has been imported during the first five months of the current fiscal year while 206,394 tonnes of LPG worth Rs. 23.75 billion was imported in the same period last fiscal year.

Cooperatives close, leaving depositors in distress

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bhairahawa, Jan. 1

Many co-operatives operating in Rupandehi have been closed without returning the money of the depositors. The latest deviations in cooperatives across the country have also impacted the cooperatives in Rupandehi district.

The depositors' money is at risk because of poor regulation of the cooperatives. The management started closing the cooperatives after the savers demanded their money back. A total of 10 cooperatives operating in the district have been shut down as they failed to return the money of the depositors.

The cooperatives that could not return the customers' savings within a year and a half closed themselves without any prior notice and none of the employees were reachable. The Shiva Shikhar Multipurpose Cooperatives at Yogikuti in Butwal was closed one and a half years ago after it was unable to return depositors money worth Rs. 30 million. Now the office of the cooperative has been removed from Yogikuti.

The depositors of cooperatives are in trouble after Shiva Shikhar Cooperatives, which produces agricultural materials and sells grocery materials, started investing daily savings of members in other businesses. This cooperative, which opened an office in Butwal three years ago, had about 1,700 members.

The multipurpose-cooperatives, including Supreme, Agantuk, Shine, Bishowbirat, Upkar, Saptadeep, Namaste, Upadesh and Sunaulo which have offices in Butwal and Bhairahawa had been shut down as they could not return the savings.

The cooperatives of Butwal have invested in micro hydro, industry, tourism and agriculture. Similarly, the cooperatives have invested in real estate and hire purchases without keeping collateral. However, there is a weak monitoring of the cooperatives by the local and provincial governments.

Bhim Tulachan, the chairman of District Saving and Credit Cooperative Union, Rupandehi, said that the cooperative invests 60 per cent of savings in business and 40 per cent in other areas such as real estate and hire purchases.

Gunakar Khanal, chief of the Cooperatives and Employment Promotion Branch of Butwal Sub-Metropolitan City, said that although there was no problem with 136 cooperatives registered in the sub-metropolis, about a dozen cooperatives registered in the federal and province have become problematic.

According to him, there are more than 215 cooperatives in Butwal, including those registered in the municipality and province. There are about 800 cooperatives in Rupandehi alone. "Around 60,000 shareholders of the Butwal Sub-Metropolitan City have invested Rs. 7.40 billion through the cooperatives," he said, "For the safety of money of shareholders, the discussions are held through the municipality to find solutions to problems every three months."

Tikaram Pokharel, Vice President of the Cooperative Development Board of Lumbini Province, said that due to the lack of effective regulation at the time of registration of cooperatives in the province, cooperatives that have opened now are causing a crisis. According to him, more than 41,000 registered cooperatives are operating in Lumbini.

Minimum-wage rise offer on New Year elates workers

AP
Albany, N.Y, Jan. 1

New York's minimum-wage workers had more than just the new year to celebrate Monday, with a pay bump kicking in as the clock ticked over to 2024.

In the first of a series of annual increases slated for the Empire State, the minimum wage increased to $16 in New York City and some of its suburbs, up from $15. In the rest of the state, the new minimum wage is $15, up from $14.20.

The state's minimum wage is expected to increase every year until it reaches $17 in New York City and its suburbs, and $16 in the rest of the state by 2026. Future hikes will be tied to the Consumer Price Index for Urban Wage Earners and Clerical Workers, a measurement of inflation. New York is one of 22 states getting minimum wage rises in the new year.

In California, the minimum wage increased to $16, up from $15.50, while in Connecticut it increased to $15.69 from the previous rate of $15. This most recent pay bump in New York is part of an agreement made last year between Democratic Gov. Kathy Hochul and the state Legislature. The deal came over the objections of some employers, as well as some liberal Democrats who said it didn't go high enough.

The federal minimum wage in the United States has stayed at $7.25 per hour since 2009, but states and some localities are free to set higher amounts. Thirty states, including New Mexico and Washington, have done so.

Bandipur begins campaign to bring tourists



PHOTO: AMAR RAJ NAHARKI/TRN

Bandipur rural municipality chairman Surendra Thapa presenting souvenir to the travelers.

BY AMAR RAJ NAHARKI
Tanahun, Jan. 1

The Bandipur Rural Municipality has begun a campaign to attract tourists to the eponymous hill station. Under the campaign, tourism entrepreneurs and hoteliers of Bandipur plan to travel to different cities of the country to promote the settlement known as the 'Queen of the hills.'

According to Surendra Thapa, chairman of the rural municipality, campaigners have already travelled to Rupandehi, Palpa and Syangja and interacted with elected representatives, businesses and industrialists there. Thapa informed that the campaign had the objective to make the rural municipality prosperous through tourism.

Kisan Pradhan, chairman of the Bandipur Tourism Development Committee, hoped that the campaign would promote Bandipur. "The area is already gradually developing as a destination for domestic and foreign tourists. We hope this campaign will help bring more visitors," he said.

Bandipur is known for its mediaeval Newa architecture, scenic views of Annapurna, Machhapuchchhre and Dhaulagiri mountains, temples of Khaddevi, Bindhyabasini and Mahalaxmi, and beautiful places like Thanimai, Teendhara, Raniban, Ramkot and Sunkhari.

LITHIUM BATTERY FIRE IN A CARGO SHIP IN CONTROL AFTER SEVERAL DAYS

AP
Anchorage, Alaska. Jan. 1

After lithium-ion batteries burned in a large cargo ship's hold for a number of days, the U.S. Coast Guard said late Saturday that the fire was out and directed the ship to anchor near Dutch Harbor, Alaska.

The 19 crew members of the ship, Genius Star XI, were uninjured and technicians from the Salvage and Marine Firefighting team remain onboard to ensure the fire doesn't return, according to a Coast Guard press release. "This protected anchorage ... will allow the vessel to remain stable, minimizing risk of any re-flash of the fire as we continue our response," Capt. Chris Culpepper said in the press release, which said an investigation into the fire's origins will begin once response efforts wrap up.

Genius Star XI was shipping lithium-ion batteries from Vietnam to San Diego. The crew alerted the Coast Guard early Thursday morning to the fire, after pumping carbon dioxide into hold No. 1 — where the blaze began — and sealing it, fearing an explosion.

The Coast Guard diverted the 410-foot (125-meter) cargo ship to Dutch Harbor, one of the nation's busiest fishing ports located in Unalaska, an Aleutian Islands community about 800 miles (1,287 kilometers) southwest of Anchorage.

Arriving Friday, Genius Star XI was kept 2 miles (3.2 kilometers) from shore to mitigate the risks of toxic gases produced by the fire to the community and environment while responders worked to extinguish the flames, Coast Guard Lt. Cmdr. Mike Salerno said in an email to The Associated Press. There have been no oil leaks associated with the fire, according to the ship's owners, Wisdom Marine Group.

Orange festival to ensure its market



RSS
Muglin (Chitwan), Jan. 1

Orange festival is being organised at Ichchhakamana rural municipality of Chitwan from today. The three-day festival being organised with an objective of ensuring market of orange incorporating Tokdand, Dhap, Majhgaun, Sirangaun and Dode villages of the rural municipality. A large quantity of orange is produced in these villages.

Chairperson of Ichchhakamana rural municipality, Dan Bahadur Gurung, shared that the orange festival is going to be organised for the first time with on objective of ensuring market orange produced by local farmers and its promotion. "We have made arrangement where festival visitor can pick and eat orange by climbing tree", he added. Similarly, orange eating contest would also be organised in the festival.

Chair Gurung said orange would be kept at a discounted price as compared to market in the festival as well as different materials would be distributed to orange farmers and a training would also be imparted to farmers by agriculture technicians. "We are organising the festival with a belief that it will be easy to sell orange produced in Ichchhakamana rural municipality at different markets of the country as well as it will help for the publicity of tourism sites of the area", he mentioned.

It is estimated that more than 450 farmers of Ichchhamana rural municipality would sell orange worth Rs 100 million this year. Farmers are now selling orange at Rs 75-90 per kg from their farms. Orange is cultivated on 80 hectares of land in the rural municipality this year, according to the Agriculture Development Section of the rural municipality. A total of 1650 metric tonnes of orange was produced in the rural municipality last year.

No Nepali will be deprived of medical treatment: Health Minister Basnet



PHOTO: PUSHKAR BHANDARI/TRN

Minister for Health and Population Mohan Bahadur Basnet addressing a gathering after inspecting the Dadeldhura Hospital, Monday.

PUSHKAR BHANDARI
Dadeldhura, Jan. 1

Minister for Health and Population Mohan Bahadur Basnet has said that no Nepali will be deprived of medical treatment due to a lack of money.

After inspecting the Dadeldhura Hospital, which is preparing to begin Bachelor in Medical Lab Technology (BMLT) classes next month, Minister Basnet said that health was a fundamental right and that the state would take responsibility for it.

There have been instances of people having to leave hospitals due to poor financial condition and losing their lives at home, the Minister lamented. "The poor need not die. The state should guarantee this. And, as the Health Minister and a representative of this state, I guarantee this," he remarked.

"If poverty prevents anyone from getting the treatment they need, send them to us. We will make sure they get the proper care. Nepalis should no longer have to die for not having money."

Basnet hoped that the medical college would transform the Dadeldhura Hospital, but advised it to proceed gradually. "You currently have a 100-bed hospital, but if you seek to add 400 more beds overnight, you may not be successful," he cautioned.

At the same time though, he said that the ministry had begun work to expand the hospital's capacity to 300 beds. "Things are currently held up at the Ministry of Finance, but I think it will pass." The Minister also shed light on the condition the Health Ministry was working in. The number of job positions at the ministry has not increased since 1997 and its budget ceiling had been decreased by 40 per cent this fiscal year.

"The Ministry of Finance said that they could not give more money because our ministry did not work last year. Nevertheless, we persuaded them to add Rs. 13 billion to our budget," he shared. Despite the limited resources and bureaucratic hurdles, Basnet claimed that he was able to get the cabinet to pass some health policies and documents that had been pending for nearly 16 years.

Basnet emphasised the need for places like Dadeldhura to produce health workers from within their populace because those coming from outside do not stay for long. Noting that the district's hospital would begin BMLT classes from February 12, he urged to upgrade itself to be able to start Bachelor of Medicine and Bachelor of Surgery (MBBS) classes.

Seven students provided scholarship

Vice-Chancellor of Far Western University Amma Raj Joshi informed that the Medical Education Commission had allowed the Dadeldhura Hospital to enrol 10 students for the BMLT course. Of them, seven students have already received admission with scholarships.

Joshi shared that they had asked the Commission to provide the hospital 20 seats but were granted only 10. "Nevertheless, we are happy to be taking this step into medical education and plan to begin MBBS classes three years later," he told The Rising Nepal.

Dadeldhura Hospital needs to have at least 300 beds before it can receive permission for MBBS classes.

ELECTION OFFICE FOR NA POLL SET UP IN GHORAHI

BY OUR CORRESPONDENT
Ghorahi, Jan. 1

The office of the election officer has been established in Ghorahi of Dang district for the upcoming National Assembly member election scheduled for January 25.

The office of the election officer was established on the premises of the Lumbini Province Election office in Ghorahi Municipality-15.

Kripasur Karki, election officer, informed that the office was set up as per the requirement for the upcoming National Assembly election.

"Now that the office is open for work, all the necessary preparations for the election will take place according to the schedule," said Karki.

The nomination of the candidates for the National Assembly election is scheduled for January 8.

The term of 19 elected and one nominated NA members is expiring on March 3. Election for the two seats in the National Assembly will be held in Lumbini Province. Karki and Laxmi Dutta Kalauni, Head of Lumbini Province Election Office, were present at the office opening ceremony.

ELEPHANTS CAUSE CROP DAMAGE IN ISHWARPUR

RSS
Sarlahi, Jan. 1

Two wild elephants caused damage to the crops in the Srinagar area of Ishwarpur Municipality-13 in the district on Sunday night. The elephants caused extensive damage to the potato and other vegetables planted by Krishna Bahadur Ale Magar in his two katthas of land in Srinagar Ale Tole.

Tilak Lama, Ward Chairman of Ishwarpur Municipality-13, said that the elephants, however, did not damage the houses because the entire villagers gathered and drove them away from the crop farms before they reached the houses.

The wild elephants first appeared in the ward a few weeks ago. They are appearing in different areas of Ishwarpur in Sarlahi and Bardiwas and Gaushala Municipalities in Mahottari.

Every year, the elephants that arrive in the forest area of the Sagarnath Forest Development Project damage human settlements and farmers' crops.

Devchuli Danda now popular hiking destination



PHOTO: MEENA KANDEL/TRN

A scenic view of Devchuli Danda (Hill) in East Nawalparasi.

BY MEENA KANDEL
Kawasoti, Jan. 1

Devchuli Danda (Hill) in East Nawalparasi is now becoming popular among hiking enthusiasts, particularly during holidays and festivals.

Tourists visit it to enjoy the scenic mountain views from its top. One can enjoy panoramic views of various areas in Nawalpur, as well as glimpses of Tanahun, Palpa, Kaski, and Chitwan. The sight of the stunning snow-capped range to the north brings immense joy to anyone reaching this point. The hill also has a religious importance.

Looking south from the Hill, one can observe the Narayani River, the densely populated settlements along the East-West Highway, Chitwan National Park, and the plains. Birendra Parajuli, Chairperson of the Federation of Nepalese Journalists, Nawalparasi chapter, noted that it is a wonderful and quiet place in nature and a delightful destination to visit.

He added, "Indeed, Devchuli Hill, one of the tallest hills in eastern Nawalparasi, is an incredibly enjoyable place. The view of the snow-capped range from the mountain, the peaks, and the gap seen to the south are incredibly charming."

Stairs and railings have been built with financial assistance from the provincial government to ensure the convenience and safety of tourists climbing the hill. Travellers climb using the stairs and pause at rest stops along the way to pay homage to Tin Kanya Mai and observe the legendary caves from the Mahabharata period.

Superintendent of Police and District Police Chief Narahari Regmi said that mesh netting has been installed to ensure the safety of the visitors at the narrow and steep eastern side of the hill's peak.

For the development of the Devchuli Tourism Area, a connecting road is being constructed from its base in Kirtipur Village. Mayor of Devchuli Municipality Hari Prasad Neupane informed that the municipality has initiated the construction of the trek with Rs. 2 million from the Tourism Development Board and Rs. 2.2 million allocated by the municipality.

As homestay facilities are available, tourists can stay overnight, savour local mountain dishes, join the cultural programmes, and start the trek in the morning.

Visitor's book started

Devchuli Hill is reached by crossing dense forests, with only a few houses in sight and small trails. To reach the hill from the Devchuli Pond, one needs to travel around 20 kilometres north from Daldale. It is about 12 kilometres from Kirtipur. Following that, the journey continues on foot. After an around three-hour trek, one can reach the hill. The hill lies at an altitude of about 1,934 metres above sea level.

With the growing number of tourists trekking the Hill, a visitor's book has been kept. Meen Bahadur Soti Magar, Ward Chairman of Ward No. 6, informed that maintaining a record of tourist arrivals will facilitate accurate tracking of data.

Highlighting the importance of a master plan for the holistic development of the Hill, especially from a tourist perspective, Magar added that constructing infrastructure such as roads, electricity, and drinking water up to the upper base camp is essential.

Santosh Rana, president of Nawalpur District Hoteliers Association, said that by developing places like Devchuli and other sites, the residents of the district can potentially find employment opportunities locally, limiting the need to go abroad for work.

INVITATION FOR BIDS

Nepal Electricity Authority
(A Government of Nepal Undertaking)
Transmission Directorate
Grid Development Department
Bafikot-Khungri 132 kV Transmission Line Project

Invitation for Bids for the:
Design, Supply, Installation, Testing and Commissioning of Bafikot-Khungri 132 kV Transmission Line Contract Identification No: ICB-NEA/ BKTLP/ TL/ 080/ 81-01

Date of publication : January 02, 2024

1. **The Government of Nepal** [GoN] has allocated funds towards the cost of **Bafikot-Khungri 132 kV Transmission Line** and intends to apply part of the funds to cover eligible payments under the Contract for **Design, Supply, Installation, Testing and Commissioning of Bafikot-Khungri 132 kV Transmission Line** Bidding is open to all eligible Nepalese and Foreign Bidders.
2. **Nepal Electricity Authority** invites electronic bids from eligible bidders for the construction of Design, Supply, Installation, Testing and Commissioning of Bafikot-Khungri 132 kV Transmission Line under International Competitive Bidding – Two Envelope Bidding procedures.
   a. Minimum Average Annual Construction Turnover of the best 3 years out of last 10 fiscal years: 10.50 million USD
   b. Bidder must demonstrate access to, or availability of, financial resources such as liquid assets, unencumbered real assets, and other financial resources, (other than any con tractual advance payments) to meet the cash-flow requirement of 1.75 million USD.
   c. Minimum Bidding capacity of the bidder should be equal to or more than 16.80 million USD.
   d. Experience under construction contracts in the role of contractor, subcontractor, or management contractor for at least the last Five (5) years prior to the applications submission deadline.
   e. Participation as Prime contractor, management contractor, or subcontractor, in at least One (1) EPC/ Turnkey/ DB Contract within the last ten (10) years, with a value of at least 12.60 million USD that have been successfully or are substantially completed and that are similar to the proposed works. The similarity of the Bidder's participation herein shall be based on Design, Supply, installation, testing and commissioning of Transmission Line, or Design, Supply, Installation, testing and commissioning of Transmission Line and Substation in a single contract, Where the voltage level must be 132 kV or higher.
   f. The Bidder shall have successfully executed as a prime contractor, management contractor, or subcontractor, the transmission line contracts for design, supply, installation, testing and commissioning of at least 1 (one) transmission line contract of 132 kV or above voltage The line length of transmission line shall not be less than 120 circuit km.

   All work experiences shall be demonstrated with notarized end-user certificates (on the letterhead of the end users). The references of the parent or subsidiary companies of the bidder/ s shall not be considered for the evaluation. In case of a Joint venture, the above capabilities need to be satisfied by the partners as mentioned in the qualification criteria.
3. Eligible Bidders may obtain further information and inspect the Bidding Documents at the office of

   The Project Manager
   Bafikot-Khungri 132kV Transmission Line Project
   NEA Training Centre, Kharipati, Bhaktapur, Nepal
   Phone : +977 9849095461
   Email : bk132kv@nea.org.np
   Or may visit PPMO website www.bolpatra.gov.np/ egp.
4. A complete set of Bidding Documents may be purchased from the office of the Project Manager, Bafikot-Khungri 132kV Transmission Line Project, Kharipati, Bhaktapur by eligible Bidders on the submission of a written application, along with the copy of company/ firm registration certificate, and upon payment of a non-refundable fee of **NPR 20,000.00** till **March 02, 2024** during office hours.

   Or

   Download the bidding documents for e-submission from PPMO's Web Site www.bolpatra.gov.np. Bidders, submitting their bid electronically, should deposit the cost (as specified above) of bidding document in the Project's Rajaswa (revenue) account as specified below and the scanned copy (pdf format) of the Bank deposit voucher shall be uploaded by the bidder at the time of electronic submission of the bids. Information to deposit the cost of bidding document in Bank:

   Name of the Bank : Nabil Bank Limited
   Name of the account. : NEA Bafikot Khungri 132 KV TLP
   Bank Address. : Corporate Office, Kathmandu
   Office Account no. : 00201017505705
5. Pre-bid meeting shall be held at the office of the **Project Manager, Bafikot-Khungri 132kV Transmission Line Project, Kharipati, Bhaktapur at 12:00pm on February 07, 2024.**
6. Electronic bids must be submitted to the office of **the Project Manager, Bafikot-Khungri 132kV Transmission Line Project, Kharipati, Bhaktapur** through PPMO website www.bolpatra.gov.np/ egp. on or before 12:00pm on March 02, 2024. Bids received after this deadline will be rejected.
7. The bids will be opened in the presence of Bidders' representatives who choose to attend at **1:00 pm** on **March 02, 2024** at the office of the **Project Manager, Bafikot-Khungri 132kV Transmission Line Project, Kharipati, Bhaktapur.** Bids must be valid for a period of **120 days** after bid opening and must be accompanied by a bid security or scanned copy of the bid security in pdf format in case of e-bid, amounting to a minimum of **550,000.00 USD,** which shall be valid for 30 days beyond the validity period of the bid **(i.e. July 30, 2024).**
8. If the last date of purchasing and / or submission falls on a government holiday, then the next working day shall be considered as the last date. In such case the validity period of **the bid and bid** security shall remain the same as specified for the original last date of bid submission.
9. In the case of discrepancies or error in bid documents, bid notice or any other document, the NEA reserves the right to amend and correct at any time.
10. After the completion of evaluation of Technical Bid for substantial responsiveness, substantially responsive bidders will be invited to attend the opening of Price Bids. The date, time and location of opening of Price Bid shall be notified in writing and/ or published in national daily newspaper.
11. NEA reserves the right to accept or reject wholly or partly or all bids at any stage before contract agreement without assigning any reason whatsoever.

Cigarette Smoking is Injurious to Health

THOUGHT FOR TODAY

It is in your moments of decision that your destiny is shaped.
-- Tony Robbins

EDITORIAL

Shelter For Quake Victims

Over 13,500 temporary houses have been built in Rukum West and Jajarkot, the worst affected districts by November 3 earthquake, with the grant given by the government to the victims. An additional 9,341 temporary houses are under construction in Rukum West, where the victims – who number 19,717 – have also received the first tranche of the assistance money (Rs. 25,000 each). There, a total of Rs. 592 million is said to have been transferred from the Local Disaster Fund so far for the construction, providing much-needed cash to construct 7,079 houses in Athbiskot Municipality, 3,014 of which have been completed while 4,100 are under construction.

In Chaurjahari Municipality, construction of 265 temporary houses has been completed while the construction of 2,400 is in progress. Similarly, 3,042 houses have been constructed in Sanibheri Rural Municipality while another 2,203 are being built. In Triveni Rural Municipality, 617 houses have been built and 550 are in the works. Similarly, 117 houses have been built in Banphikot Rural Municipality and 40 are under construction. The amount of first tranche for 23,608 beneficiaries from the District Disaster Fund has been sent to the disaster fund of respective local levels. The local levels have deposited Rs. 493 million in the accounts of 19,717 beneficiaries.

In Chaurjahari Municipality, Rs. 150 million has been sent from the District Disaster Fund for 6,279 beneficiaries, while the municipality has deposited 148.4 million in the accounts of 5,938 beneficiaries. What's more, Rs. 175 million sent for 7,000 beneficiaries in Aathbiskot Municipality has been similarly deposited. Likewise, 10,096 beneficiaries in Jajarkot received Rs. 253.3 million grant to build temporary houses.

Of the 20,344 who signed an agreement to receive the grant, only 10,096 got the first tranche of the grant, out of which 6,598 have built the houses. The more houses get built, the more likely that they will be able to stay safe from the biting winter cold, as well as from the potentially dangerous weather conditions. With the thousands of houses already constructed and more in progress, it seems that the government has adequately mobilised its machineries and provided the capital to step up the reconstruction effort. It also seems that the shortage of skilled manpower to construct the houses – the problem faced in the early days – has been effectively sorted out.

Amid this encouraging progress, care must be taken to ensure that the affected – especially the elderly, the infirm, those with special needs, expectant mothers, newborns, among others – get the care they need. The people will surely get a roof over their heads. But will they be able to piece together their shattered lives? Some are living with deeply embedded trauma which may prevent them from living a happy life. They are in desperate need of psycho-social counselling, among other supports, to be able to lead a life that is in no way cumbersome to them as well as their families.

Besides, the chorus of complaints that many victims were not getting enough clothes to stay warm appears to have been muted. It means that this concern has also been addressed. Education had been another casualty. If students are still out of school, necessary measures must be taken to get them back to classrooms. And, when permanent structures are constructed, there must be a mechanism in place to ensure that they respect the seismic safety guidelines and building code for quake resilience.

Otter Conservation To Save Wetland Ecology

PRABIN LAMA

Otters, belonging to the Mustelidae family, are peculiar owing to their feeding habit and their way of living. These animals can attract tourists and help promote wildlife tourism. Otters are known for their playful behaviour having long, streamlined bodies and webbed feet which make easier to walk, swim, groom, and handle prey. They are cute creatures that swim around, hold hands, and appear to be having a lot of fun all the time. Their antics can easily attract anyone, as they are playful and intelligent creatures. They have the potential to be used as umbrella species in a variety of aquatic habitats which can have an umbrella effect and help protect other species.

The majority of otter species enjoy clean water with little human interference and depend primarily on fish and crustaceans in the wild. Otters are considered as indicators to the health of the aquatic environment. Their presence marks the sign of healthy ecosystem. They are important for freshwater diversity conservation. It is a key wetland species and has pivotal role in river ecosystems. Since, they are predators they help in regulating the populations of the species they feed on.

All 13 species of otter found in the globe are put in the IUCN Red List of threatened species. With the exception of the North American river otter, whose population is thought to be steady, all other otter species are in decline. Nevertheless, this is debatable because trapping results in the legal deaths of tens of thousands of individuals annually. Five Otter species live in South East Asia. Among them three were present in Nepal in the study conducted by Bryan Hodgson in 1990s. In recent times, Smooth coated otter and Eurasian otter have been documented in Nepal. But there is lack of evidence to confirm whether the small clawed otters are present in Nepal or not.

According to several studies, otter numbers in Nepal have drastically decreased in recent decades due to hunting and degradation of natural habitats. They are hunted for their meat, internal organs, and pelt for use in traditional medicines. Otter habitats are becoming increasingly unsuitable due to increased human disturbances in wetland areas, increasing deforestation, and transformation of wetland areas into agricultural lands. Otters are yet to receive conservation attention. Some scattered records are available about their geographic distribution, population size, preferred habitats, and other traits. Studies conducted so far are insufficient.

Connecting conservation of the otter species to the livelihood of local people can be fruitful for the conservation of these species. Otters prey on fish and there is always some kind of conflict between otters and fishery entrepreneurs. Diversifying the livelihood of local fishermen is also crucial. The biggest issue in otter conservation is the lack of awareness. Majority of Nepali populace is unaware that otters exist in Nepal. People who live close to wetland habitats can greatly benefit from management programmes highlighting ecological characteristics such as habitat, diet preferences, their role in ecosystems and conservation issues. It is important to raise awareness in the neighborhood and among fishermen which can gradually persuade locals to recognise otters as an essential component of freshwater ecosystem.

There is a close connection between wetlands and otters, and it is our responsibility to protect these significant ecosystems for the sake of otters, other wetland animals, and eventually ourselves.

Worrying Issue Of Foreign Employment

Narayan Upadhyay



Two youths, aspiring to go to South Korea as migrant workers, died in a police firing last Friday, bringing to our attention the pathetic condition of the foreign employment system in the country. Had the responsible authorities acted wisely and honestly, the two Nepali youngsters, each hailing from Accham and Dailekh districts, would not have died. While the police personnel deployed to maintain order were guilty of resorting to unnecessarily excessive force, the Employment Permission Service (EPS) Office failed to act in time to quell the rising tension of youths gathered in and around its office in Lalitpur, which resulted in the deaths of two aspirant workers and the torching of a minister's vehicle.

The incident compelled the government to take prompt action against the culprits, which included the Lalitpur Chief District Office, the police head who ordered the firing, and the EPS chief, who was guilty of worsening the situation by making contradictory statements over the past few weeks. A high-level committee to investigate the death has also been formed. It promptly provided one million rupees in compensation to the families of each of the two deceased youths. But these acts from the government appear to be too little for the families who have lost their sons for no fault of their own.

Unethical practices

In the case of EPS failure, which led to Friday's event, the office had not allowed several aspirants, who had successfully passed the language examination to work in the South Korean shipyards, to appear in another examination, which would make them eligible to work in agriculture and other production sectors. But the EPS office denied their request, resulting in the angry outbursts of the youths on Friday. After the incident, the office had now allowed all of them to appear in the examination. This further shows how unwise and irresponsible our authorities are. In the meantime, reports accuse the EPS office and many of its employees of being involved in unethical and inappropriate acts of charging higher fees and ticket prices to Nepali youths who become eligible to fly to Korea as workers.

Friday's incident, which grabbed the attention of the nation, is a grim reminder that the country's foreign employment sector is hewn with several forms of anomalies. Several members of such responsible authorities, expected to manage the sector, are often found involved in unethical practices. Besides Nepalis willing to go to Korea, other migrant workers visiting the Gulf countries, Malaysia, and many other nations fall victim to greedy manpower companies as well as officials of the foreign management and immigration offices. Nepalis willing to enter the USA, Canada, and European nations are often taken for a ride and are taken on long and windy routes. Many of them face obstacles, and in recent times, several of them have died.

Reports suggest that a strong nexus among the manpower agents, immigration, and other officials is at work. It is quite difficult for authorities to bust such a nexus. With the growth in the number of Nepalis leaving the country, the nexus remains at its place because it has become profitable for them to earn fast bucks.

Youths in Nepal appear to be increasingly willing to leave the country in search of greener pastures. Many want to go abroad to pursue studies in the hope that they will get jobs while continuing their studies. While persons who have not attended higher education desire to go abroad as unskilled, semi-skilled, and skilled labourers. According to a government report, about 110,000 students received no objection letters from the Ministry of Education to study abroad last fiscal year, which, however, does not account for those students who have gone to India to pursue their studies. Nepal's colleges have now started to see a dwindling number of students. Many colleges have been forced to close due to a lack of students. Various sectors have started witnessing shortages of workers in the country. Besides, many individuals who have already been working in government offices, including doctors and engineers, have now been opting to fly to nations like the USA, Australia, Canada, and the UK, citing that Nepal lacked opportunities for them. According to census data, about 450,000 young Nepalis enter the labour force each year after completing their undergraduate and higher education degrees. Unfortunately, only approximately 15 percent of them find work in Nepal, where they frequently earn the minimum wage. Families are thus forced to send their relatives abroad in pursuit of a better future.

> The police force must be asked to exercise maximum restraint while controlling crowds and foreign employment offices, and manpower agents must be closely monitored.

As the lure of foreign employment grows, Nepal's urban areas and villages have started witnessing an exodus of youth workers. Many families are without youth members, and several villages are without youths. A recent census report tells us that Nepal's mid-hill districts have shown a reduction in their population, which has forced the government to rethink its development policies for these districts.

Way forward

In the meantime, it is also true that the alarming migration of Nepali youths and work force is likely to continue in the days ahead as developed nations of the world continue to look for work force. The offer of high salaries and a better standard of living will continue to attract our youth. The government authorities cannot stop worrying about the level of migration to countries that promise to provide permanent residential status or a green card, as long as it fails to match the benefits that are provided by rich and developed nations to foreign students and job seekers.

The situation has indeed put our authorities in a dilemma. However, the authorities can facilitate youths who aspire to go as migrant workers to destinations like Korea, the Gulf, and a few other nations. They should address all the difficulties being faced by these workers, who provide remittances to a country that has indeed worked wonders for our economy in recent times. Meanwhile, it is crucial for our authorities to remain wary of repeating Friday's incident in any part of the nation. The police force must be asked to exercise maximum restraint while controlling crowds and foreign employment offices, and manpower agents must be closely monitored.

(Upadhyay is former managing editor of this daily)

Ensure Sustainable Water Management

Uttam Maharjan



Water woes in the Kathmandu Valley are acute these days as in the past. The Melamchi Drinking Water Project has almost been completed but there are still snags. The national pride project, which started in November 2001, began distributing water to the Kathmandu Valley in March 2021. The project has a capacity of supplying 170 million litres of water a day. The people were elated when they enjoyed the baptism of the supply of water from the Melamchi River but their elation turned into frustration when the water supply came to an end in June of that year after the flash floods destroyed the infrastructure of the project, including its dam and water treatment plant. Since then, the water supply from the Melamchi has been erratic. Now also, there is no water supply from the Melamchi River.

The scarcity of drinking water in the Kathmandu Valley can be attributed to burgeoning urbanisation driven mainly by migration from the rural areas, increasing population, over-exploitation of groundwater and the like. There is constant boring for underground water, resulting in the subsidence of aquifers. It is surmised that the water table is shrinking 80 centimetres a year. With this, groundwater has been contaminated with concentrated nitrates and arsenic. These chemicals are harmful to the human body. Drilling deeper and deeper for groundwater for drinking and other purposes has also affected the sources of stone spouts (dhunge dharas). There are fewer than 300 stone spouts left in the Kathmandu Valley, out of which over half have dried up.

Preserving water sources

Stone spouts were the only sources of water in the past. With the introduction of the piped water supply system, the stone spouts were disregarded. And with construction works for big buildings and what with negligence, the stone spouts began to dry up. The famous Sundhara stone spouts dried up with the construction of the Sanchaya Kosh building. Climate change has also affected the water supply in the Kathmandu Valley. Climate change has made the monsoons irregular. Climate change has also affected the Himalayan ecosystem, which is a source of water for water bodies like rivers.

Water is a common good. The problem of water is not only limited to Nepal; it has become a worldwide problem. That is why, the Sustainable Development Goals have also encapsulated the water goal. SDG 6 aims at ensuring clean drinking water and sanitation for all. In fact, water is linked to every aspect of human life such food security, public health and economic and political stability. It would be relevant to mention the UN Conference on Water (March 22-24, 2023). The conference proved to be common forum for governments, businesses and communities to make commitments to a sustainable future for water in order to achieve global water and sanitation goals. The conference aimed at tackling the global water crisis by dealing with the scarcity of water, pollution, natural disasters (three fourths of natural disasters are induced by water) and climate change, and by re-establishing water as a global common good. The conference adopted the Water Action Agenda aimed at safeguarding the world's most valuable shared resource – water. The agenda included nearly 700 commitments ranging from strengthening monitoring and data systems to beefing up infrastructure resilience through capacity-building efforts.

The government has accentuated the concept of integrated wager resources management in the National Water Resources Strategy, National Water Plan and other relevant policies. The Water Resources Policy of Nepal, 2020 outlines 11 strategies for sustainable and optimal use of water resources. The government has also initiated the protection of existing water sources by including climate change adaptation and disaster risk reduction in water supply projects as a national policy. But proper institutional arrangements and the implementation mechanism are not robust enough to materialise the concept. Consequently, the government has not succeeded in its endeavour to deal with challenges relating to water: water scarcity, deteriorating water quality and water-induced natural disasters such as floods.

> If only the distribution mechanism could be made more systematic, the water woes could be mitigated to a great extent.

The government should focus on preserving water resources through effective action plans, policies, innovative technology and community engagement. The community engagement in community forestry is exemplary, which is a matter of pride. This is mostly responsible for improving the community forestry sector. Such public engagement should also be emulated in the water sector. It should design a green infrastructure mechanism, a mechanism that aims at restoring stone spouts and ponds, restoring adjacent forest areas and green areas and counteracting the over-exploitation of aquifers so that the water table may not sink further. Now, emphasis is laid on water use and infrastructure. The government should emphasise water conservation and management on a sustainable scale. Further, the government should revamp the institutional framework and the implementation mechanism for sustainable water management.

Rainwater harvesting

Rainwater harvesting could be a good option for overcoming water woes to some extent in the Kathmandu Valley. The Valley residents should, therefore, be motivated to go for rainwater harvesting. And it may be made mandatory for new houses to install a rainwater harvesting facility. The government says that even the Melamchi water will not be able to meet the growing demands for water in the Kathmandu Valley. The government is planning to bring water from the Yangri and Larke Rivers to the Kathmandu Valley. These rivers will supply 340 million litres of water on a daily basis. But the Valley denizens are not confident that the Yangri and Larke drinking water project will be completed anytime soon. The Melamchi project is still wobbling.

The Kathmandu Upatyaka Khanepani Limited (KUKL) is responsible for managing drinking water in Kathmandu. But the management of supplying water to households in Kathmandu seems to be poor. Some households get more than enough water, while others get no water at all. If only the distribution mechanism could be made more systematic, the water woes could be mitigated to a great extent. Further, the quality of water is often questioned. Sometimes, the water contains dirt and sediments, making it unfit for drinking or other uses. So the management of the KUKL also needs to be improved.

(Maharjan has been regularly writing on contemporary issues for this daily since 2000.)

50 YEARS AGO

THE RISING NEPAL

January 2, 1974

Petrol Supply Cut Down By 30 PC

Kathmandu, Jan.1: The supply of petrol to Nepal has been cut down by 30 per cent, according to Nepal Oil Corporation, reports RSS.

NOTICE TO CONTRIBUTORS

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Please email your contributions to:

trnfeatures@hotmail.com
trnfeatures@gmail.com

Or send them to
P.O. Box 23, Kathmandu, Nepal

READER'S MAIL

Support Orange Farmers

I am writing to express my concerns about the alarming decline in orange production in Ilam, Nepal, mentioned by the news report "*Ilam farmer happy his orange orchard earns Rs. 1 million*" published in this daily on Jan 1.

The story of the hardworking farmer, who sold his orchard after years of dedicated care, sheds light on the struggles faced by local farmers due to various factors like diseases, insects, and adverse climate effects.

The dwindling orange production, as shared by the Agriculture Knowledge Centre in Ilam, is distressing.

With only 2,740 tonnes produced this year compared to 2,744 tonnes last year, it's evident that several challenges, including disease outbreaks, insect infestations, and inadequate agricultural practices, are taking a toll on the region's orange cultivation.



It's essential for authorities to take urgent action to support these farmers. Initiatives such as orchard management strengthening programmes could be pivotal in mitigating the destruction of orange gardens and sustaining orange cultivation in Ilam.

The plight of these farmers necessitates collective efforts to overcome challenges and restore orange cultivation in our region.

Deepesh Gautam
Jhapa

TAILPIECE

I recently had a visitor from the state of Texas. For three days all I heard from him was "In Texas we have the best this, the largest that, the fastest that," etc. It eventually became very annoying.

Being from Niagra Falls, I thought I could outdo him by showing him the "Mighty Niagara", knowing there was nothing in Texas that could compare to this "Wonder of Water and Power".

While standing at the brink watching millions of gallons of water rushing over, I noticed the look of awe in his eyes. It was then I asked him: "Do you have anything like this in Texas?"

He waited a moment before he answered: "No, but we have a plumber that could fix it."

Thousands hold anti-Israeli protest in Istanbul



PHOTO: AFP

Erdogan has repeatedly lashed out at Israel.

AFP
Istanbul, Jan. 1

Tens of thousands marched in Istanbul Monday to protest "murderer" Israel's war in Gaza and the killing of Turkish soldiers by outlawed Kurdish militants in Iraq.

The rally, called by a foundation which counts Bilal Erdogan, the son of President Recep Tayyip Erdogan, among its members started after crowds performed morning prayers at Istanbul's iconic mosques, including Hagia Sophia and the Blue Mosque.

Protesters waving Turkish and Palestinian flags rallied to the Galata Bridge on the Bosphorus chanting: "Murderer Israel, get out of Palestine" and "Allahu Akbar" (God is the greatest).

Tens of thousands of people joined the rally "Mercy for our martryrs and a curse on Israel", the official Anadolu news agency reported.

Erdogan, a vocal supporter of the Palestinian cause, has lashed out repeatedly at Israel for the scale of death and destruction caused by its response to Hamas' unprecedented October 7 cross-border attack.

He has accused Israel of "state terrorism" and said Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu was "no different" from Adolf Hitler.

The nearly three-month war in Gaza was triggered by Hamas's bloody October 7 attacks on Israel, which killed around 1,140 people, most of them civilians, according to an AFP tally based on official figures.

Fighters also took around 250 people hostage that day, most of whom remain in Gaza, according to Israeli officials.

Israel vowed to destroy Hamas in response, launching a punishing offensive in the Gaza Strip that has reduced vast areas to a ruined wasteland and killed at least 21,822 people, mostly women and children, according to the territory's health ministry.

The Israeli army says 172 of its soldiers have been killed inside Gaza, with the war showing no signs of stopping.

The Turkish army said 12 soldiers were killed in late December in two separate attacks launched by the Kurdistan Workers' Party (PKK) in northern Iraq.

Japan warns of tsunami after earthquakes

AFP
Japan, Jan. 1

A succession of 21 earthquakes registering 4.0 magnitude or stronger struck central Japan in just over 90 minutes on Monday, the Japan Meteorological Agency said.

The strongest jolt measured 7.6, it said. The quakes prompted tsunami warnings and authorities urged people in the area to move to higher ground.

"All residents must evacuate immediately to higher ground," national broadcaster NHK said after the quake hit the Noto region in Ishikawa prefecture around 4:10 pm (0710 GMT).

Hazardous tsunami waves were possible within 300 kilometres (190 miles) of the quake's epicentre along the Japan coast, the Hawaii-based Pacific Tsunami Warning Center said.

A tsunami of 1.2 metres was confirmed to have arrived in Wajima city in Ishikawa prefecture.

But a much higher tsunami of five metres was expected to arrive in Noto in the same region, the Japan Meterological Agency (JMA) said.

The JMA said the Noto region, on the Sea of Japan side of Japan's main island of Honshu, experienced a rapid succession of quakes, starting with a 5.7 magnitude tremor at 4:06 pm local time.

This was followed by a 7.6-magnitude quake at 4:10 pm, a 6.1 magnitude quake at 4:18 pm, a 4.5 magnitude one at 4:23 pm, a 4.6 magnitude quake at 4:29 pm, and 4.8 magnitude quake at 4:32 pm.



PHOTO: REUTERS

Road cracks caused by an earthquake are seen in Wajima, Ishikawa prefecture, Japan on January 1, 2024.

Another quake with a magnitude of 6.2 hit soon after, the US Geological Survey said.

The largest of the quakes prompted broadcasters to switch to special programming and make urgent calls for affected residents to leave for higher ground.

"We realise your home, your belongings are all precious to you, but your lives are important above everything else. Run to the highest ground possible," a presenter on broadcaster NHK told viewers.

Japan has strict construction regulations intended to ensure buildings can withstand strong earthquakes and routinely holds emergency drills to prepare for a major jolt.

But the country is haunted by the memory of a massive 9.0-magnitude undersea quake off northeastern Japan in March 2011, which triggered a tsunami that left around 18,500 people dead or missing.

The 2011 tsunami also sent three reactors into meltdown at the Fukushima nuclear plant, causing Japan's worst post-war disaster and the most serious nuclear accident since Chernobyl.

In March 2022, a 7.4-magnitude quake off the coast of Fukushima shook large areas of eastern Japan, killing three people.

The capital Tokyo was devastated by a huge earthquake a century ago in 1923.

Israeli strikes in central Gaza kill at least 35

AP
Gaza Strip, Jan. 2

Israeli strikes in central Gaza killed at least 35 people Sunday, hospital officials said, as fighting raged across the tiny enclave a day after Israel's prime minister said the war will continue for "many more months," resisting international calls for a cease-fire.

The military said Israeli forces were operating in Gaza's second-largest city, Khan Younis, and residents reported strikes in the central region, the latest focus of the nearly three-month air-and-ground war that has raised fears of a regional conflagration.

The U.S. military said its forces shot and killed several Iran-backed Houthi rebels when they tried to attack a cargo ship in the Red Sea, an escalation in a maritime conflict linked to the war. And an Israeli Cabinet minister suggested encouraging Gaza's population to emigrate, remarks that could worsen tensions with Egypt and other friendly Arab states.

Israel says it wants to destroy Hamas' governing and military capabilities in Gaza, from where it launched its Oct. 7 attack on southern Israel. The militants killed some 1,200 people after breaking through Israel's extensive border defenses, shattering its sense of security. They also captured around 240 hostages, nearly half of whom were released during a temporary cease-fire agreement in November.



PHOTO: AP

Palestinians visit the graves of people killed in the Israeli bombardment of the Gaza Strip and buried inside the Shifa Hospital grounds in Gaza City, Sunday, Dec. 31, 2023.

Just after midnight on New Year's Day, Hamas militants fired a barrage of rockets, setting off air raid sirens in southern and central Israel. No injuries were reported.

Displaced Palestinians found little to celebrate on New Year's Eve in Muwasi, a makeshift camp in a mostly undeveloped area of southern Gaza's Mediterranean coast designated by Israel as a safe zone.

"From the intensity of the pain we live, we do not feel that there is a new year," said Kamal al-Zeinaty, huddled with his family around a fire inside a tent. "All the days are the same."

Russia launches record number of drones across Ukraine

AP
Kyiv, Ukraine, Jan. 1

Russia launched a record 90 Shahed-type drones over Ukraine during the early hours of the new year, the Ukrainian air force said Monday, while Russia also reported Ukrainian attacks.

A 15-year-old boy was killed and seven people wounded after falling debris from one of 87 downed drones hit a residential building in the city of Odesa, the head of the region's military administration, Oleh Kiper, said. Debris also sparked a number of small fires, including at the city's port.

In the western city of Lviv, Russian attacks severely damaged a museum dedicated to Roman Shukhevych, a controversial Ukrainian nationalist and military commander who fought for Ukrainian independence during World War II. University buildings in the town of Dubliany were also damaged, although no casualties were reported.

Writing on social media, Lviv mayor Andriy Sadovyi described the strike as "symbolic and cynical," adding, "this is a war for our history."

Meanwhile, four people were killed and 13 more wounded following Ukrainian shelling on Russian-occupied areas of Donetsk, according to the area's Russian-installed leader, Denis Pushilin. Russian state media reported that a journalist was among the victims, but provided no further details.

One person was also killed and another wounded in shelling on the Russian border town of Shebekino, regional governor Vyacheslav Gladkov said.

The aerial strikes follow a series of heavy aerial bombardments that began on Friday, when Russia unleashed an 18-hour attack that one air force official described as the biggest aerial barrage of the war.

At least 49 people were killed in the bombardment, with rescuers in Kyiv reporting Monday that they had recovered at least eight more bodies from underneath the rubble.

Shelling blamed on Ukraine in the center of the Russian border city of Belgorod Saturday killed 21 people, including three children, local officials reported.

PRISM

Escaped dog goes for a run

Wisconsin: A runaway dog was reunited with his family in Wisconsin after leading police on a chase on a snowy stretch of highway. The Wisconsin Department of Transportation said its cameras first recorded a dog on the westbound Beltline between Gammon Road and Whitney Way about 9:30 a.m. Thursday. A traffic jam ensued as emergency vehicles pursued the dog, who continued to flee.

The dog was eventually captured safely and turned over to animal control.

The owners of the dog, named Thor, said they were on a cruise in the middle of the ocean when Thor escaped while being walked by a neighbor three days before he found his way to the highway.

Thor was later reunited with his family.

Chinese jump rope trio break record

China: A trio of Chinese jump rope champions broke a world record when a member of the team performed 176 double-under skips in 1 minute while simultaneously jumping long rope.

The long rope was held by coaches Wang Huanan and Kan Qingru while Liu Xinzhu, 14, Kan's daughter, vaulted over it while swinging her own short rope for double-under skips. Liu Xinzhu managed 176 consecutive jumps, earning the Guinness World Records title for the most double under skips while jumping long rope simultaneously in 1 minute

The mother and daughter were both members of the Chinese national jump rope team at the 2022 Asian Championships.

(Agencies)

TODAY IN HISTORY

1777 – American Revolutionary War: American forces under the command of George Washington repulsed a British attack at the Battle of the Assunpink Creek near Trenton, New Jersey.
1788 – Georgia becomes the fourth state to ratify the United States Constitution.
1942 – World War II: Manila is captured by Japanese forces, enabling them to control the Philippines.[
1963 – Vietnam War: The Viet Cong wins its first major victory, at the Battle of Ap Bac
1993 – Sri Lankan Civil War: The Sri Lanka Navy kill 35–100 civilians on the Jaffna Lagoon.
2022 – Massive nationwide protests and unrest break out in Kazakhstan over the sudden increase of liquefied petroleum gas prices, leaving over 200 people dead and thousands injured.[
1975 – The Federal Rules of Evidence are approved by the United States Congress.

The year in clean energy

Wind, solar and batteries grow despite economic challenges

AP
New York, Jan. 1

Led by new solar power, the world added renewable energy at breakneck speed in 2023, a trend that if amplified will help Earth turn away from fossil fuels and prevent severe warming and its effects.

Clean energy is often now the least expensive, explaining some of the growth. Nations also adopted policies that support renewables, some citing energy security concerns, according to the International Energy Agency. These factors countered high interest rates and persistent challenges in getting materials and components in many places.

The IEA projected that more than 440 gigawatts of renewable energy would be added in 2023, more than the entire installed power capacity of Germany and Spain together.

China, Europe, and the U.S. each set solar installation records for a single year, according to the International Renewable Energy Agency.

China's additions dwarfed those of all other countries, at somewhere between 180 and 230 gigawatts, depending on how end-of-the-year projects turn out. Europe added 58 gigawatts.

Solar is now the cheapest form of electricity in a majority of countries. Solar panel prices fell a whopping 40% to 53% in Europe between December 2022 and November 2023 and are now at record lows.

Particularly in Europe, it's been really at breakneck speed of scaling up the deployment, said Michael Taylor, senior analyst at IRENA.

When the final numbers for 2023 are in, solar energy is expected to surpass hydropower in total capacity globally, but for actual electricity produced, hydropower will still make more clean power for some time because it can produce around the clock.

In the United States, California continues to have the most solar energy, followed by Texas, Florida, North Carolina, and Arizona.

Both state and federal incentives had a large influence on U.S. solar growth, said Daniel Bresette, president of the Environmental and Energy Study Institute, a nonprofit education and policy organization.



PHOTO: AP

Rain clouds move over wind turbines near Aschersleben, Germany, Oct. 29, 2023.

Despite solar's success in 2023, there are hurdles. There has been a shortage of transformers, Bresette said, while interest rates have risen.

In the U.S., solar manufacturing grew as well. "We have seen the impact of the Inflation Reduction Act in terms of fueling investments ... more than 60 solar manufacturing facilities were announced over the past year," said Abigail Ross Hopper, president and CEO of the Solar Energy Industries Association. By the end of 2023, the world will have added enough wind energy to power nearly 80 million homes, making it a record year

As with solar, most of the growth, or more than 58 gigawatts, was added in China, according to research from Wood Mackenzie. China is on track to surpass its ambitious 2030 target of 1,200 gigawatts of utility-scale solar and wind power capacity five years ahead of schedule if planned projects are all built, the Global Energy Monitor said.

China was one of the few growing markets this year for wind, the Global Wind Energy Council said. Faster permitting and other improvements in key markets such as Germany and India also helped add more wind energy. But installations were down in Europe by 6% year-over-year, Wood Mackenzie said.

Short-term challenges such as high inflation, rising interest rates and increased costs of building materials forced some ocean wind developers to renegotiate or even cancel project contracts, and some land-based wind developers to delay projects to 2024 or 2025.



PHOTO: RSS

Students performing Hudkeli folk dance at an education fair held in Mahendra Nagar of Bhimdutta Municipality-4, Kanchanpur district on Monday.

House panel seeks probe into Balkumari incident

'Shots fired after siege of minister's vehicle'

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 1

The State Affairs and Good Governance Committee of the House of Representatives has instructed the government to investigate the role of the Ministry of Labour, Employment and Social Security and the Minister of Physical Infrastructure and Transport in the Balkumari incident.

After a discussion with Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha in the meeting of the Committee held on Monday, the Committee instructed to investigate the role of two ministries in the incident of firing during the demonstration by youths demanding a Korean language test even if they had failed in shipbuilding category test.

Announcing the decision of the Committee, President Ramhari Khatiwada of the Committee said, "Instructions have been made to investigate the role of the Ministry of Labour, Employment and Social Affairs and the Ministry of Physical Infrastructure and Transport to prevent the repetition of such incidents."

Meanwhile, Deputy Prime Minister and Minister for Home Affairs Narayan Kaji Shrestha said that gunshots were fired on Friday when Physical Infrastructure and Transport Minister Prakash Jwala's vehicle were besieged at Balkumari.

Addressing the House of Representatives' State Affairs and Good Governance Committee, Minister Shrestha detailed the sequence of events leading to the use of force.

According to Minister Shrestha, police resorted to firing when they were informed that Minister Prakash Jwala's car was under siege at the protest site.

He also acknowledged weaknesses in three areas regarding the Balkumari incident that occurred on Friday, resulting in two casualties and physical losses.

The Minister said that the initial conclusion on the incident highlighted the EPS Office Chief's role was not positive, the security officials assigned to the Minister for Physical Infrastructure and Transport failed to fulfil their responsibilities, and there was a weakness on the part of the field commander of the Nepal Police.

He attributed the incident to the negligence of the EPS office, the PSO's decision to relocate the minister's vehicle, and the inadequacy of security personnel.

Minister Shrestha criticised the EPS office's policy of not deploying individuals who failed in the shipbuilding test to production, emphasising its negative impact on a significant number of people.

He cited a reported interaction between the head of peace and security at the Ministry of Home Affairs and the EPS head, highlighting concerns about the latter's dismissive response.

During the parliamentary committee's inquiry, Minister Shrestha noted attempting to move the minister's car away from the protest site as a serious error by the PSO.

He asserted that had Minister Jwala's car taken a different route, the situation would not have escalated.

Questioning the security protocols, Minister Shrestha pondered why the security guard and PSO did not intervene.

He criticised the PSO's failure to follow standard procedures, such as checking the path in advance and heeding instructions from the control room.

Detailing the events leading to the firing, Minister Shrestha mentioned that shots were fired after Minister Jwala's vehicle was besieged.

He noted injuries, including one person shot and another affected by tear gas, while emphasising that an investigation was underway into the nature of the weapons used.

Responding to the committee's queries, Minister Shrestha acknowledged a mistake by security personnel, emphasising that they were instructed not to use force under any circumstances.

Despite the challenging situation, he stressed the Ministry of Home Affairs' commitment to maintaining peace and security.

Minister Shrestha also expressed the need for a thorough investigation, characterising the incident as an unusual case with initial analysis suggesting a systemic weakness that cannot be ignored.

Similarly, Inspector General of Nepal Police (IGP) Basanta Bahadur Kunwar has said that such an incident would not have happened in Balkumari if Physical, Infrastructure and Transport Minister Prakash Jwala had not arrived there on last Friday.

On Monday, IGP Kunwar while answering questions at the meeting of the State Affairs and Good Governance Committee of the House of Representatives that if Minister Jwala had not reached there on that day, the incident would not have happened.

General force was used at 11:30 a.m. At 11:52, the Minister was going to Koteshwar from a party venue. At the same time, PSO did not acquire information about the situation. At 11:54 a.m., there was a scuffle," said IGP Kunwar.

"PSO took the minister to a safe place. The minister's vehicle was then set on fire at around noon. It is not clear when the shots were fired. If the minister's car had not come, this incident would not have happened," said IGP Kunwar.

The IGP said that the police lost their patience when it appeared that the demonstrators tried to set Minister Jwala's vehicle on fire with him inside it.

IGP Kunwar also claimed that if force was not used in the Balkumari incident, more damage would have incurred.

Cold wave affects life in Tarai belt

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan.1

Winter is now at its peak. However, Nepal has not yet witnessed a usual drop in temperature. Almost all parts of Nepal, including Kathmandu, have recorded above-average temperatures till Monday, the first day of the year, when the minimum temperature of the capital city was recorded 6.0 degrees Celsius.

Sanjeev Adhikari, a senior meteorologist at the Meteorological Forecasting Division under the Department of Hydrology and Meteorology, said that the forecasted above-normal rainfall for the winter season, from December to February, was yet to be received. "So, the temperature has not dropped significantly due to the lack of winter rain," he added.

Adhikari said, "The temperature in Kathmandu has recorded above-normal levels this year compared to last year. There is no indication of a swift decrease in temperature in Kathmandu shortly, and there is also no forecasted change in rainfall."

Meanwhile, the temperature in the Tarai region has remained chilly, prompting the people there to make fires to keep themselves warm.

Our correspondent from Sarlahi said the districts of Tarai, including Sarlahi has been grappling with extreme cold for the past three days, making life increasingly challenging for its residents.

The disadvantaged individuals lacking warm clothing to protect themselves from the cold have started making fires. Tragically, in these harsh weather conditions, individuals from low-income families, including Musahar, have to face hardships in the rural settlements of the Tarai.

Laxmi Paswan, a resident of Haripur Municipality-2, expressed concern about the impact of the intensifying cold weather on Musahar and other extremely impoverished families in their area.

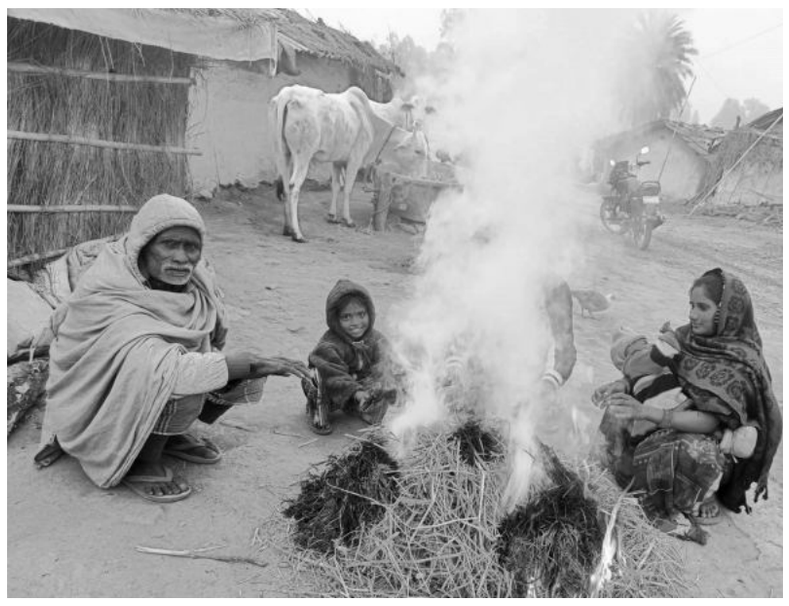
She said, "Mushar and other marginalised Dalit families, lacking warm clothing are suffering a lot. Unfortunately, there is no initiative to distribute firewood to provide them with much-needed warmth."

The surge in cold temperatures has led to an uptick in the trade of warm clothes in the main markets of the district, including Lalbandi, Malangwa, Harion, Bayalbas and Barahathwa.

Raj Karan Sah, a clothing trader at Lalbandi Bazaar, said that the demand for warm clothing such as jackets, hoodies, turtle necks, trousers, hats, and socks has increased significantly due to the colder weather.

Similarly, our correspondent, Shiva Shankar Mishra, from the Bara district reported that the cold has impacted various parts of Tarai districts. The chilling temperatures have affected most districts of the Tarai, including Bara, Parsa, and Rautahat. In these areas, a decrease in public participation, particularly in places like markets, has been noted due to the biting cold winds during the morning and evening hours.

The weather has turned extremely cold with chilly winds persisting since morning. The cold conditions are posing additional challenges, particularly for daily wage earners and ordinary individuals who earn their livelihoods through outdoor labour.



Among those significantly affected are rickshaw pullers and construction workers who work outside the confines of their homes.

Lotan Mali Bhagat, a labourer from Mahagadhimai Municipality-10, expressed the difficulty they face in working due to the harsh cold.

Doctors said that the cold has more impact on children and the elderly, urging special attention to avoid it. They recommend consuming hot food accompanied by hot water.

Dr. Rakesh Tiwari, a physician in Kalaiya, has advised people to take necessary precautions during the cold weather. He recommends avoiding outdoor activities in the morning, and for those who need to venture outside, he suggests wearing warm clothes to protect against the harsh conditions.

According to Adhikari, the temperature in the Tarai has also not dropped significantly, as observed in previous years. However, the mornings have felt notably cold due to the presence of fog, contributing to a chilling sensation experienced by people. Adhikari also noted that there was no substantial difference between the maximum and minimum temperatures throughout the day, which is called diurnal temperature variations.

Bayberry ripens before usual time

BY SHER BAHADUR SARKI
Bajura, Jan. 1

Bayberry, known as "kafal" in Nepali, began ripening in January, well ahead of its usual season in June.

Nare Budha, a local of Badimalika Municipality, said that kafal, which used to ripe in June/July, has started ripening in the month of January.

He said, "This could be attributed to the impact of global warming, and its effects are now becoming evident at the local level as well. As a result, kafal started ripening ahead of the usual timetable."

Previously, only a handful of plants outside the district would typically ripen in January. However, this time, the fruit started ripening within the district as well, said Budha.

Kafal is delicious and has numerous health benefits. The powder derived from ripe kafal is known to ease ailments like diarrhoea and dysentery. Additionally, the powder obtained from its bark is utilised for treating burns and conditions like ringworm infestation.

National Reconciliation...

"I do not want to throw a stone at the current pond created by the Nepali Congress, which is satisfied with its role in the current administration of the state. I don't want to disturb any state of peace," he said.

Oli talked about his achievements during his time in power and said that there should be a reasonable counter rather than a direct attack on those accomplishments by opposition parties.

Oli also asked questions about the actions of authorities during the Balkumari protest which led to the death of two youths and asked for a quick probe into the incident.

Oli reiterated that his party wants to move forward by reconciling with political parties on the issue of nationalism, good governance, prosperity and development of the country.

With the idea of staying among the people to protect the sovereign power of the country, the NC leaders including Koirala, Ganeshman Singh, Shailaja Acharya and Khum Bahadur Khadka had returned to Nepal risking their lives during the Panchayat period in 1977.

Economy not steady yet, says CNI

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 1

A recent survey of the Confederation of Nepalese Industries (CNI) has found no improvement in the economy in the first quarter of the current Fiscal Year 2023/24 compared to the situation in the previous FY 2022/23.

While the government has been reiterating the reforms in the economy citing the positive indicators in the balance of payment, foreign exchange reserve, gradually decreasing bank interest rates as well as increasing remittance and decreasing imports, the private sector body's research has concluded otherwise.

"It is seen that the overall demand in the market has gone down. The price of raw materials is constantly rising. It seems that there has been a decline in the import of raw materials of the industry," showed the CNI study which was made public on Monday.

"Due to the adverse economic conditions, the morale of the industrialists and businessmen was seen to be weak last year, which has remained the same even in the current year. According to the survey, last year 69.44 per cent of industrialists and businessmen said that they had postponed their investment plans, while in the first quarter of this year, 55.32 per cent of industrialists and businessmen said that they had deferred their investment plans.

It is our understanding that the economy has not improved as claimed by the government, said President of the CNI, Rajesh Kumar Agrawal. The survey has made a comparative study of the first quarter of the last three fiscal years.

According to the survey, the overall market demand for industrial products decreased by 28.28 per cent last year. It has been seen that it has further decreased by 12.06 per cent during the same period of the current fiscal year.

Compared to the same period of 2022/23, there has been a total contraction of 36.93 per cent in the overall demand of industries in 2023/24. Similarly, the turnover of industries has decreased by 24.94 per cent in the previous year while it went down by 7.46 per cent in the same period of this year.

In comparison to the 2021/22, industrial turnover has decreased by 30.54 per cent.

"The government of Nepal and the regulatory bodies have been arguing that the economy has improved since the last few months after accepting the reality of the economic slowdown. However, this claim is based on the data of the external sector of the economy," said the CNI.

According to Agrawal, in order to assess the reality of the economy, the CNI has conducted a survey at the industry business level in order to assess the reality of the economy when such data and claims of the government do not match with the experience and fact analyses of the public, private sector and the media.

Sector-wise analysis shows that the overall demand of the cement industry has contracted by 7.36 per cent compared to the previous year. It had decreased by 40.17 per cent at the same time last year.

Similarly, last year, the amount of turnover of such industries had decreased by 39 per cent, but in the same period of the current year, there has been a further decrease of 9.54 per cent.

Likewise, the overall demand in the construction sector has gone down by additional 16.20 per cent than that of the previous year. It had plummeted by 43.43 per cent in the same period last year. Compared to the situation in 2021/22, the total demand of this sector has contracted by a total of 52.59 per cent in 2023/24.

In the first quarter of the previous year, the demand of the FMCG (fast moving consumer goods) sector increased by 2.50 per cent, but the study found that this year it has declined by 17.70 per cent. In comparison to 2021/22, the total demand of this sector has contracted by a total of 15.64 per cent now.

SENIOR JOURNALIST GOKUL POKHREL PASSES AWAY



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 1

Senior journalist and former Editor-In-Chief of Gorkhapatra, the sister daily of this publication, Gokul Prasad Pokhrel passed away on Monday. He was 87.

Pokhrel was one of the few journalists in Nepal to excel both in Nepali and English language journalism.

He joined The Rising Nepal in 1965, immediately after its publication began, as its Senior Editor. Before joining this daily, he was working with the National News Agency (RSS). Later, he shifted to the Gorkhapatra daily and served as its Editor-in-Chief.

Pokhrel also worked as the Editor of Muna, the monthly magazine.

Pokhrel was a founding member of Nepal Press Institute (NPI) established in 1984. It is the first institute established in Nepal to train journalists.

Pokhrel is survived by his wife, two daughters and a son.

Music serves as social interlocutor for Subedi

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan.1



Songwriter Prakash Subedi, who eloquently expresses social realities through his songs, wears multiple hats as a creative writer, songwriter, producer and documentary maker.

He has crafted a diverse range of songs that appeal to kids, lovebirds, and individuals with nationalistic aspirations.

Subedi is a versatile songwriter, catering to various age groups and themes.

His lyrical ability has resulted in wonderful musical creations, thanks to collaborations with renowned musicians such as Suresh Adhikari, Basanta Sapkota, Hari Lamsal, Laxman Shesh, Shree Krishna Bam Malla, Sagar Sarad Adhikari, and others.

Additionally, Subedi's popular songs have been brought to life by prominent singers like Swaroopraj Acharya, Shiva Pariyar, CD Vijaya Adhikari, Kamal Khatri, Anjana Gurung, Melina Rai, Milan Newar, Raj Sagar and Anju Panta.

His collaboration with musicians has led to the creation of a child psychology-based song titled 'Jati Maya Lagchha Mamuko' (the more I love my mom) and the nationalistic song 'Tukriyeke Desh Haina' (not a divided country), where Prisha and Swaroopraj Acharya lent their voices.

In 'Jati Maya Lagchha Mamuko', the impact of family feuds and the separation of a couple on children's psychology is vividly portrayed.

Similarly, the lyrics of 'Tukriyeko Desh Haina' urge rulers to avoid political wrangling, opting for reconciliation over short-lived political slogans.

Furthermore, Subedi has penned introductory and promotional songs for Rupa Rural Municipality, Dakshinkali Municipality, and Panauti Municipality, highlighting their social, economic, religious, touristic and ecological potentials.

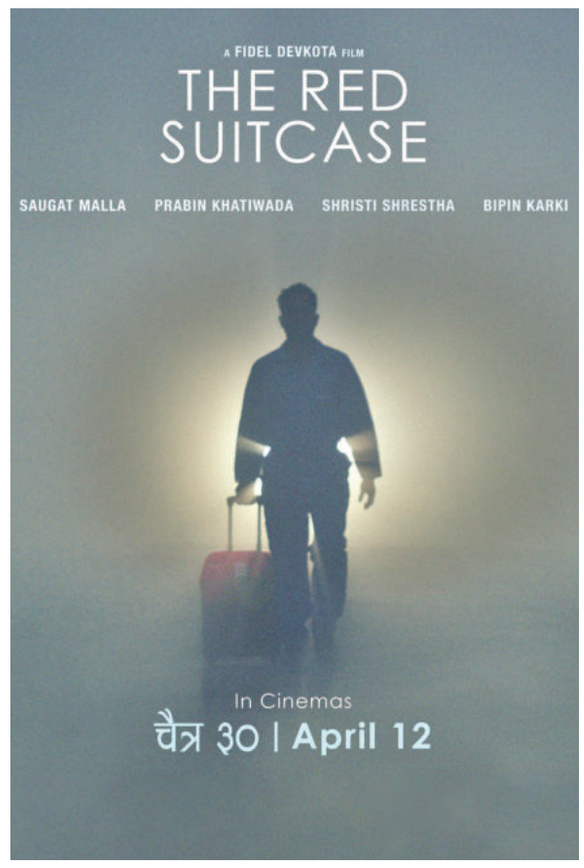
He also wrote a song encouraging youth to hone their skills before seeking foreign employment or exploring opportunities at home, earning him the Rapti Award for Best Message Song.

Interestingly, Subedi wrote a song advocating for good governance and against corruption, titled 'Santatile Dhikkarlan Feri'.

He emphasises that songs should also serve social causes, and lyricists should respect social richness and diversity.

The Red Suitcase on April 12

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 1



The Red Suitcase, which has travelled to various prestigious film festivals worldwide, is now set to be released in the cinema halls. Announcing a film poster on the occasion of the New Year, the production unit announced the film's release date.

The film is set to hit the cinema halls on April 12.

Directed by Fidel Devkota, the story is narrated against the setting of myths, immigrant traditions and the destiny of Nepal.

The film had its world premiere at the Venice Film Festival in September last year and garnered two important awards.

Since then, it has been selected at the Mannheim-Heidelberg International Film Festival in Germany, the Zurich Film Festival in Switzerland, and the Mumbai Film Festival in India, all considered one of the oldest film festivals in the world.

Producer Ram Krishna Pokharel said that the film has received a lot of love from foreign audiences, prompting them to screen the film with the expectation of a similar level of love from the domestic audience.

Director Fidel Devkota said that the film is a mirror of contemporary society and tries to explore the unyielding issues prevalent in society.

The movie received the Honourable Mention Award at the 'Fondazione Fai Persona Lavoro Ambiente' category during the Venice Film Festival.

Additionally, the independent critics' jury awarded the Best Feature Film Award to director Fidel Devkota as a debut director under the 'Bisato d'Oro' category at the same film festival.

The film also won the Best Debut Feature Film award at the recently concluded Jaffna International Cinema Festival in Sri Lanka. The film featured artists like Saugat Malla, Bipin Karki, Prabin Khatiwada and Srishti Shrestha.

Harisiddhi Art Mela today

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 1

The Rotary Club of Yala, together with Hamro Matoghar, E-Arts Nepal and Chiva Chaitya, is set to organise the Harisiddhi Art Mela in Harsiddhi, Lalitpur, on Tuesday.

According to the organisers, the Mela will exhibit over 50 artworks by 22 contemporary artists, musical performances, art workshops, stalls featuring local products and Newari food. The Mela will be inaugurated by the oldest man and woman from the settlement of Harisiddhi at 10 am.

Issuing a press release, the Mela team informed that the event was being supported by wards 28 and 29 of the Lalitpur Metropolitan City, as well as community leaders and local schools.

This Mela is part of a campaign to expose Newa settlements in the fringes of the Kathmandu Valley, raise awareness of Kathmandu's heritage and culture, and empower young artists.

Asha Dangol, coordinator of the event, told The Rising Nepal that the Mela was the first programme under the campaign and that the next event would be held at Lubhu, Lalitpur, although the date has not yet been decided.

Harisiddhi Art Mela is a one-day event that will be held at Harisiddhi Niva, Harisiddhi from 10 am to 5 pm.

'Wonka' ends the year No. 1 at the box office

AP
New York, Jan. 1

Hollywood closed out an up and down 2023 with "Wonka" regaining No. 1 at the box office, strong sales for "The Color Purple" and an overall $9 billion in ticket sales that improved on 2022's grosses but fell about $2 billion shy of pre-pandemic norms.

The New Year's weekend box office this year lacked a true blockbuster. (This time last year, "Avatar: The Way of Water" was inundating theaters.) Instead, a wide array of films – among them "Aquaman and the Lost Kingdom," "The Boys in the Boat," "Migration," "Ferrari," "The Iron Claw" and "Anyone But You" – sought to break out over the year's most lucrative box-office corridor.

The top choice, though, remained "Wonka," Paul King's musical starring Timothée Chalamet as a young Willy Wonka. In its third weekend, the Warner Bros. release collected an estimated $24 million Friday through Sunday and $31.8 million factoring in estimates for the Monday holiday. That brings the film's domestical total to $142.5 million.

That bested Warner Bros.' own "Aquaman and the Lost Kingdom," which, like previous DC superhero films, is struggling. James Wan's "Aquaman" sequel starring Jason Momoa took in $19.5 million in its second weekend to bring its two-week haul to a modest $84.7 million including New Year's Day estimates.



The original "Aquaman," which ultimately surpassed $1.1 billion worldwide, had grossed $215.4 million over a similar period in 2018 – more than double that of the sequel. Internationally, "Aquaman and the Lost Kingdom" added $50.5 million.

Weekend sales only tell part of the story this time of year. From Christmas through New Year's, when kids are out of school and many adults aren't working, every day is like Saturday to film distributors.

"The Color Purple," Blitz Bazawule's adaptation of the 2005 stage musical from Alice Walker's novel, debuted on Monday and led all movies on Christmas with $18 million. Through the week, the Warner Bros. release has grossed $50 million, including $13 million Friday through Sunday. That's a strong start for the crowd-pleaser starring Fantasia Barrino, Taraji P. Henson and Danielle Brooks. Audiences gave it an "A" CinemaScore.

The roughly $100 million production, which boasts Oprah Winfrey, Steven Spielberg and Quincy Jones (all from the 1985 film) as producers, should play well through awards season. It's nominated for several Golden Globes and expected to be in the Oscar mix.

Amar Aakash's Tungna released



BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 1

Poet Amar Akaash's debut collection of poems Tungna was released amid the presence of literary figures in the capital on WHEN???

Senior poets Shailendra Sakar, Hari Adhikari, Yuyutsu RD Sharma, poet Aakash himself, critic Rajkumar Baniya, Shyam Rimal, librarian Jujubhai Dangol and director of White Lotus Book Shop Shreejana Bhandari jointly made the book public at a function organised by White Lotus Book Shop.

Poet Akash began the programme by reciting two of his famous poems 'Jhalkaman' and 'Messiah Puppy'. 'Jhalakman' depicted the heartbreaking story of all suppressed and Dalit people through singer Jhalakman Gandarva while 'Messiah Puppy' told the story of little hope of a depressed man who survived committing suicide.

Critic Baniya pointed out that Akash's poems were fresh and original, full of vivid images and soaked in the cultural heritage of Kathmandu's people. "He writes poems by squeezing his own heart," he said.

Poet Sakar mentioned Amar as a strong and talented young poet who wrote poems based on aesthetics of Kathya Kayakalp (Content Metamorphosis), a literary movement that Sakar initiated with his fellow poet Yuyutsu Sharma a few decades ago.

Hari Adhikari said he felt delighted to read Aakash's poetry. "I found a strong possibility of more powerful poems from the poet in the days ahead," he said.

Yuyutsu Sharma called Aakash the true successor of the great Nepali poet Gopal Prasad Rimal. "A new star has emerged on the horizon of Nepali poetry as Amar Aakash," he said.

Published by White Lotus Book Shop, the 116-page book has 40 poignant poems of miscellaneous contents.

According to Bhandari, the book is available in bookstores in Kathmandu along with online platforms such as Amazon, Daraz, and Flipkart for readers worldwide.

HOROSCOPE

tarot.com

Aries: To-do list? More like "already done" list! While you may be a little more irritable than usual, Aries, you also have the verve to get tons done -- as long as you can channel this energy into your desired goals.

Taurus: Drama may explode at any moment! You're probably might not expecting any issues, but someone could be pushing your buttons in a way that you haven't felt in ages, drawing deep emotions to the surface.

Gemini: What you're used to may presently seem odd to others. You likely believe that you're acting normally, but other people could be reacting strangely to whatever you're doing.

Cancer: Your communications may not sit well with someone in your life. They might misunderstand whatever you're trying to say and react in a way that makes you feel as though your connection isn't as strong as you had hoped.

Leo: It's easy to lose sight of goals today. Distractions may arrive as impulse buys or lively friends. No matter how solid your plan for the day was, it can slip away speedily if you let yourself get preoccupied.

Virgo: You may be a bit self-focused now. It's understandable to center yourself when you're working on a personal project, having fun, or taking care of your health, but when you're working with a team, this can provoke a "me vs.

Libra: Your energy might not be where you want it to be. Exhaustion and confusion could muddy the waters of your work, potentially obscuring your path forward -- you may entirely lose sight of your desired results.

Scorpio: Fresh friendships could take unfamiliar turns at present. It may be that you're discussing uncomfortable topics, or you may even debate each other around a subject on which you disagree, but don't worry -- this should still turn out for the best.

Sagittarius: You can get by with a little help from your friends. You'll potentially have an opening to speak your mind in a very public way today -- maybe at something personal, like a wedding or a graduation, or even professional public speaking.

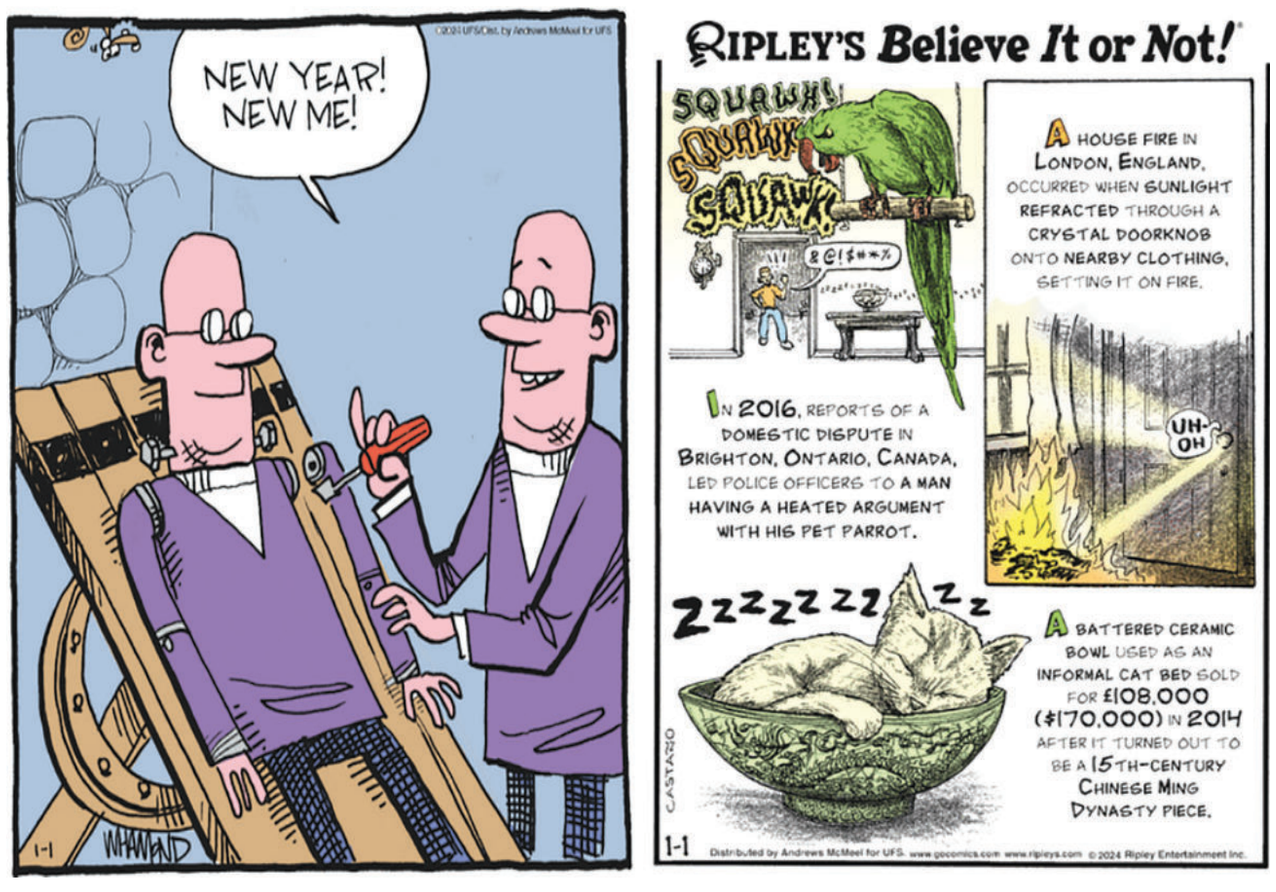
Capricorn: It's hard to know what you don't know. That is, you might need more education when it comes to an activity or subject that you're trying to be knowledgeable about, since the day's energy may make it difficult to know where to even start.

Aquarius: You might not be on the same level as those around you. Maybe a concert has you less pumped than the rest of the audience, or perhaps your pals are all psyched for a premiere that simply doesn't have your attention.

Pisces: It might be difficult to get your point across at present. An authority figure, such as a boss or a parent, could be standing between you and your goals.

CARTOON

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Koshi fix title showdown with APF at PM Cup



PHOTO: BIKASH/ TRN

Captain of Koshi Province Rubina Chhetry batting during the Qualifier 2 match of PM Cup Women's National T20 Cricket Tournament against Sudurpaschim Province at TU Cricket Ground, Kirtipur, Monday.

BY A STAFF REPORTER
Kathmandu, Jan. 1

Koshi Province secured their spot in the Prime Minister (PM) Cup Women's T20 National Cricket Tournament title match against APF Club after defeating defending champions Sudurpaschim Province by nine wickets in Qualifier 2 at TU Cricket Ground in Kirtipur on Monday.

Chasing a target of 89 runs, Koshi reached the goal in just 13 overs, with only one wicket lost. Kajol Shrestha was unbeaten as she scored the highest 38 runs in the match, hitting seven boundaries off 35 balls. She hit Anu Kadayat for a boundary to complete the chase with 92 runs on the board. Shrestha and her captain Rubina Chhetry combined for an impressive 59-run opening partnership.

Captain Chhetry contributed a quick 23-ball 37, smashing seven balls to the fence and one for maximum. Apsara Begam remained not out with 12 runs off 21 balls, including two fours. Sudurpaschim's Lakshmi Saud took only one wicket, conceding 25 runs from her four overs. Earlier, Sudurpaschim, who was invited to bat first, lost seven wickets to collect 88 runs in the allocated 20 overs.

Samjhana Khadka top-scored for Sudurpaschim with 24 runs off 25 balls, including four fours. Opener Bindu Rawal contributed 17 runs off 18 balls before being run out in 6.3 overs as the first wicket.

Another opener, Rubi Poddar, scored only seven runs before being trapped lbw to the bowling from Sangita Rai. Kabita Joshi was the only other batter to score in double digits with 15 runs off 29 balls. Sudurpaschim's Rewati Dhami, Anu Kadayat, Laxmi Saud, Sabitri Dhami all struggled to add single digits.

Right-arm off-break Sangita Rai finished with figures of 13-2, with Sabnam Rai, Alyssa Khadia, and Nisha Shah taking one wicket each. Sudurpaschim qualified for Qualifier 2 after defeating Bagmati Province in the eliminator match.

Koshi will face APF in the final on Wednesday, seeking revenge for their 52-run defeat in the Qualifier 1. Koshi won the PM Cup in 2020, while APF won the 2021 edition.

Arsenal falter once more at Fulham, Spurs close on top four

AFP
London, Jan. 1

Arsenal's Premier League title challenge suffered another blow in a 2-1 defeat at Fulham on Sunday, as Tottenham beat Bournemouth 3-1 to close in on their north London rivals.

The Gunners' high hopes of a first league title in 20 years have been rocked by two damaging defeats in four days.

Mikel Arteta was looking for a response after losing 2-0 at home to West Ham on Thursday but was left angered by what he described as his side's "worst performance of the season".

Arsenal remain in fourth, two points behind leaders Liverpool and level on 40 points with Manchester City, but having played a game more than both their title rivals.

"If we play like today we will be nowhere near. Today was a really difficult day to swallow," said Arteta on his side's title aspirations.

"It's a really sad day today because we didn't deserve to win the game."

Arsenal had started brightly at Craven Cottage as Bukayo Saka pounced to tap home his first goal in six games after Bernd Leno parried Gabriel Martinelli's initial effort.

But the visitors failed to build on their early advantage and Fulham hit back to snap a three-game losing run in the Premier League without even scoring a goal.

Raul Jimenez was badly missed during his three-game ban for a red card at Newcastle and the Mexican kickstarted the Fulham fightback with his fourth goal in as many games.

Former Arsenal winger Willian sent Tom Cairney free down the left and his dangerous low cross was swept home by Jimenez at the back post.

Fulham were the better side in the second half and they got their reward just before the hour mark. Arsenal failed to clear a corner and the ball broke kindly for Bobby De Cordova-Reid to smash home from close range.

Only a fine save from David Raya to deny Cairney and the crossbar from Andreas Pereira's free-kick prevented Arsenal from suffering further punishment in the pouring rain in west London. But enough damage may have been done to their title chances over the past week.

Son's parting gift

Arteta's men could even be outside the top four by the time they are next in league action in three weeks' time as Tottenham closed to within a point of the Champions League places.

Ange Postecoglou's men shrugged off a mounting injury crisis to inflict Bournemouth's first defeat in eight games.

Fifth-placed Spurs are just three points off the top with the table tantalisingly poised heading into 2024.

"We're three points off the top so if that is the difference between having a great season and where we are, I'll take it," said Postecoglou.

"When you're trying to build something you will undoubtedly come up against some challenges. I am seeing progress."

Pape Sarr's precise finish into the bottom corner opened the scoring after just nine minutes.

But the Senegalese midfielder left the field in tears midway through the first half with an injury that puts his participation in the upcoming Africa Cup of Nations in doubt.

Bournemouth will feel they should have been level before the break as the in-form Dominic Solanke hit the bar amid a flurry of chances.

Instead, the visitors were picked off in the second half.

Son Heung-min is also set to depart for a few weeks to lead South Korea at the Asian Cup.

The Spurs captain signed off in style with a thumping finish from a narrow angle before Richarlison made it 3-0.

Alex Scott pulled a goal back six minutes from time, but it was too little, too late for the Cherries, who remain in 12th.



PHOTO: AP

Tottenham's Pape Matar Sarr celebrates after scoring his side's opening goal during the English Premier League soccer match against AFC Bournemouth in London.

David Warner retires from one-day cricket



AFP
Sydney, Jan. 1

Dynamic Australian opener David Warner called time Monday on one-day international cricket ahead of his farewell Test against Pakistan this week, but kept the door open to play the 2025 Champions Trophy if needed.

The 37-year-old will pad up in his 112th and final Test in his home city Sydney on Wednesday, having plundered 8,695 runs at an average of 44.58, with 26 centuries and 36 half-centuries.

At a press conference at the Sydney Cricket Ground, he also announced his retirement from ODIs, where he has been a fixture since his debut in 2009, helping the team win the World Cup in 2015 and 2023.

"I've got to give back to the family and also on the back of that I'm definitely retiring from one-day cricket as well," he said.

"That was something that I had said through the (2023) World Cup, get through that, and winning it in India, I think that's a massive achievement.

"So I'll make that decision today, to retire from those forms, which does allow me to go and play some other (Twenty20) leagues around the world and sort of get the one-day team moving forward a little bit.

"I know there's a Champions Trophy coming up," he added. "If I'm playing decent cricket in two years' time and I'm around and they need someone, I'm going to be available."

The Champions Trophy has not been played since 2017, but is set to be resurrected in 2025 in Pakistan. Traditionally 50-over cricket, reports have said there is a push underway to make it T20. Warner leaves ODIs after 161 matches, smashing 6,932 runs at an average of 45.30, with 22 centuries. Among Australians, only Ricky Ponting with 30 has scored more one-day tons.

He will continue to be available in the T20 format, with the 2024 World Cup in the Caribbean and United States a target. Warner's decision to depart one-dayers means Australia will need a new opener for their three-match series against the West Indies in February, which follows a two-Test series in Adelaide and Brisbane.

But he will forever be remembered for the role he played in the notorious ball-tampering scandal of 2018 in South Africa.

Along with skipper Steve Smith, he was banned for a year for his part in the third Test debacle in Cape Town that saw Cameron Bancroft use sandpaper to scuff the ball before a crude attempt to conceal the evidence down his trousers.

Reflecting on his Test career, Warner said it was a "fairytale ending" to hang up his gloves in Sydney.

"I would have never imagined opening the batting for New South Wales or anyone to be honest when I first started but to be here, 112 Tests I think, I still pinch myself," he said.

He added that he would like to be remembered as someone "authentic and honest" who has "gone out there and given it his all".

Kylian Mbappe's future to dominate transfer window

AFP
Paris, Jan. 1

The future of Kylian Mbappe and his protracted courtship by Real Madrid is expected to be the key theme of the transfer window that opens in Europe on Monday.

Arsenal's search for a proven goalscorer to spearhead their challenge for a first Premier League title since 2004 could also loom large.

Manchester City meanwhile are widely expected to let Kalvin Phillips leave the club, ending a disappointing stay for the former Leeds midfielder who has failed to make his mark at the world champions.

Much attention though will again focus on Mbappe, Paris Saint-Germain's lethal finisher and the man who a year ago scored a hat-trick for France in the World Cup final only to finish on the losing side.

Real Madrid are again the main suitor for the 25-year-old whose contract at PSG expires in June -- will the 14-time European champions finally get a commitment from the player they have been pursuing for years?

It is far from certain though as Mbappe triggers an extraordinary reaction in France, illustrated when President Emmanuel Macron intervened to persuade him to stay at PSG in June 2022 when a move to Real seemed almost cut and dried.

Real are not sitting on their hands though. Endrick, the latest Brazilian starlet, will join the club from Palmeiras when he turns 18 in July 2024 for a fee reported to be 72 million euros.

Toney to the Gunners?

Arsenal's lack of a goalscoring edge could lead them to plunge into the market. For weeks, their rumoured target has been Ivan Toney, the Brentford forward whose ban for over 200 breaches of the Football Association's gambling rules ends in mid-January.

However, Brentford's decline in form which has seen them drop to within four points of the relegation places could persuade the club to hang onto 27-year-old Toney, even in the face of a big offer from the Gunners.

Kalvin Phillips was riding high when the midfielder joined City on the back of England's run to the Euro 2022 final, but he has played barely a handful of games for the club and Pep Guardiola has admitted the move never worked out.

Juventus have reportedly been keen to sign Phillips, who is desperate to force himself into England's plans for Euro 2024, but reports from Italy say the club are cooling on the idea.

A move to Newcastle looks a more realistic possibility as the Magpies look to bolster a squad seriously depleted by injuries and the 10-month ban handed down to Italian midfielder Sandro Tonali, also for gambling.

Eddie Howe's men have slumped down the Premier League table in recent weeks and the Saudi-owned club look badly in need of reinforcements if they are to qualify for next season's Champions League.

Serhou Guirassy, the prolific Guinea international who has scored 17 Bundesliga goals so far this season for Stuttgart, has also been linked with a move to Tyneside after a vote by Premier League clubs on a temporary ban on related-party loans failed to receive the required support.

Newcastle could also turn to their connections in the Saudi Pro League. They are allowed to sign players on loan from sides also controlled by their Saudi owners, however, one target, Ruben Neves, said in early December he would not accept a move to Newcastle because his family was happy in Saudi Arabia.

Liverpool forward Roberto Firmino also headed to the Saudi league in the summer, but is reportedly unsettled at Al Ahli.

The Brazilian, 32, could now be heading to their rivals Al Ettifaq, the club coached by former Liverpool captain Steven Gerrard, although Premier League strugglers Sheffield United are also said to be interested in his services.



WEATHER

Tuesday

Sunrise at 6:55 am, Sunset at 5:20 pm

Forecast for Nepal (Tuesday)

Partly cloudy in Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province and mainly fair in rest of the country. Chances of light snowfall at one or two places of the high hilly and mountainous region of Koshi Province, Bagmati Province and Gandaki Province.

Expected Temp.: 18-20 Rain Probability: 0%

Monday's Weather Record

Stations	Max. temp. (C)	Min. temp. (C)	Rain (mm)
Dadeldhura	16.2	4.3	0.0
Dipayal	24.2	5.2	0.0
Dhangadi	21.6	12.5	0.0
Birendranagar	23.0	6.1	0.0
Nepalgunj	18.5	12.2	0.0
Jumla	15.6	-5.3	0.0
Ghorahi	22.6	7.7	0.0
Pokhara	21.0	9.2	0.0
Bhairahawa	16.8	11.5	0.0
Simara	18.9	12.5	0.0
Kathmandu	18.5	6.0	0.0
Okhaldhunga	17.3	8.0	0.0
Taplejung	16.5	5.6	0.0
Dhankuta	22.8	8.5	0.0
Biratnagar	19.2	12.3	0.0
Jomsom	11.1	-4.0	0.0*
Dharan	22.0	8.7	0.0*
Lumle	17.4	6.1	0.0*
Janakpur	20.6	13.4	0
Jiri	16.4	2.7	0.0*

NEPAL RASTRA BANK

FOREIGN EXCHANGE DEPARTMENT

EXCHANGE RATES

January 2, 2024

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
Indian Rupee	100	Rs. 160.00	Rs. 160.15

Open Market Exchange Rates

For the purpose of Nepal Rastra Bank

CURRENCY	UNIT	BUYING	SELLING
U.S. Dollar	1	Rs. 132.89	Rs. 133.49
Euro	1	Rs. 146.67	Rs. 147.33
Pound Sterling	1	Rs. 169.18	Rs. 169.95
Swiss Franc	1	Rs. 157.88	Rs. 158.60
Australian Dollar	1	Rs. 90.51	Rs. 90.92
Canadian Dollar	1	Rs. 100.31	Rs. 100.77
Singapore Dollar	1	Rs. 100.71	Rs.101.16
Japanese Yen	10	Rs. 9.42	Rs. 9.46
Chinese Yuan	1	Rs. 18.72	Rs. 18.80
Saudi Arab Riyal	1	Rs. 35.44	Rs. 35.60
Qatari Riyal	1	Rs. 36.46	Rs. 36.62
Thai Bhat	1	Rs. 3.87	Rs. 3.88
UAE Dirham	1	Rs. 36.18	Rs. 36.35
Malaysian Ringgit	1	Rs. 28.92	Rs. 29.05
South Korean Won	100	Rs. 10.27	Rs. 10.31
Swedish Kronar	1	Rs. 13.20	Rs. 13.26
Danish Kronar	1	Rs. 19.68	Rs. 19.76
Hong Kong Dollar	1	Rs. 17.02	Rs. 17.10
Kuwaiti Dinar	1	Rs. 432.51	Rs. 434.47
Bahrain Dinar	1	Rs. 352.50	Rs. 354.09

Note: Under the present system the open market exchange rates quoted by different banks may differ.

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